Demonheart Adventure Demo

This booklet consists of the first chapter of the Demonheart Adventure and an additional chapter designed to be used as plot hooks and warm-ups. Chapter 0 will be available as a PDF but will not be included in the physical book.

This is the unedited text-only version of the booklet, prepared as a test document. We tried different approaches throughout the adventure, and we are excited to get our supporters' feedback.

The new mechanics, adversaries, communities, domains, and similar content that we have covered in the Demo Booklet aren't included in this Adventure Demo. We didn't want to implement that content in the adventure before getting feedback and making corrections. The final work will include more of those.

This adventure will continue to evolve.

Dream Realm Storytellers

Game Designers
Alican Develioğlu, Utku Barkın Tokalak, Eyüp Emre Erdem, Suat Deniz Vural

Writers
Alican Develioğlu, Utku Barkın Tokalak, Eyüp Emre Erdem, Suat Deniz Vural

Editor
Zeynep Yavuz

© 2026 Dream Realm Storytellers LTD
Demonheart: Adventure Demo Booklet is published by Dream Realm Storytellers, and it includes materials from the Daggerheart System Reference Document 1.0, © Critical Role, LLC. under the terms of the Darrington Press Community Gaming (DPCGL) License. More information can be found at https://www.daggerheart.com. There are no previous modifications by others.
Darrington Press™ and the Darrington Press authorized work logo are trademarks of Critical Role, LLC and used with permission.

Dream Realm Storytellers logo and Demonheart logo are trademarks of Dream Realm Storytellers. All characters
and the distinctive likenesses thereof are property of Dream Realm Storytellers.
Reserved Content:
All trademarks, proper names (including but not limited to character names, place names, and organization names), dialogues, narratives, plots, storylines, locations, characters, artwork, graphic design, visual designs, product designs, packaging designs, and trade dress are reserved and are not licensed under the DPCGL.
No part of this Reserved Content may be used, reproduced, or distributed without prior written permission.

Content Warning

Content Warning: Demonheart is the codex of evil, although we do not endorse the acts of evil, this book delves into the darker side of the stories. This demo booklet contains mature and potentially disturbing themes intended for adult audiences. Within its pages, readers may encounter references to depictions of physical violence and revenge, narratives shaped by trauma, despair, and psychological distress as well as sexual abuse. The work explores religious themes and reinterpretations that may be considered blasphemous, alongside portrayals of Hell, damnation, and infernal hierarchies. It also includes elements of body horror, transformation, and the loss of identity or autonomy, as well as mechanics and narratives involving moral corruption, coercion, manipulation, and the abuse of power.

Some sections feature suggestive or sexual themes, including desire, temptation, and arousal as part of the broader Hellscape. There are also references to self-harm, ritual sacrifice, and existential or nihilistic ideas concerning the nature of the self, suffering, and purpose. Characters within this work may be subjected to or participate in systems of domination, control, and exploitation.

These themes are presented as part of a dark fantasy setting and are not intended to endorse or trivialize real-world harm. Reader discretion is advised.

Rise of the Sinlord

Welcome to the demo booklet of Demonheart: Rise of the Sinlord. This adventure is designed for four players; however, it is easily adaptable to fewer or more. It includes the example character backstories and a part of the first chapter.

As the GM, it is your responsibility to read the relevant section beforehand and prepare for the session. As this book may contain sensitive content, you might want to discuss the topics that your players may wish to avoid and alter the story accordingly. After all, the goal is to share an experience and be satisfied with it.

The book utilizes the mechanics of Daggerheart and the setting of Demonheart. In the hands of an experienced GM, the mechanics could be easily adapted to a basic D20 roll to overcome difficulties and the narration of special features. Enjoy the adventure your way, and feel free to change anything that doesn't fit your narrative or play style.

Rise of the Sinlord

The Rise of the Sinlord refers to an event that is either unknown or long forgotten throughout history. Hell is ruled not only by Satan, but also by seven major entities known as the Sinlords, each embodying a single sin.

When all sins are embodied within a single being, that entity becomes "the Sinlord." This figure, wielding the power of all seven sin domains, possesses the ability to open gates between Hell and other realms. In turn, escape from Hell becomes possible only through the emergence of such a being.

At the beginning of the adventure, neither the characters nor the souls they encounter are aware of this truth. It will instead be revealed later in the story. The demo booklet itself does not directly engage with this event.

The Party

The party consists of four 1st-level characters who do not possess any sin domains at the beginning of the adventure. They will level up at the end of this demo booklet, once their encounter with the Poet is resolved.

Only then will they truly enter Hell and have a chance to gain its benefits. Upon becoming a natural part of Hell, the characters may also change their subclasses, as this is a realm where the limitations of the self begin to lose meaning. Through sin domains, they will gain access to 66 new subclasses.

You can begin playing *Demonheart: Rise of the Sinlord* with this demo booklet, and once the full book is released, the adventure will continue.

Using this Book

This book provides everything you need to run this adventure, except the system basics provided with Daggerheart.

Some of the adversaries are provided in the Daggerheart System Reference Document (SRD), while some are new. If it is in the SRD, it is written in **bold**. Otherwise, either it is present on the current pages, or it is in the Adversaries section of this book.

There are difficulties presented in parentheses throughout the adventure. It is up to the GM and players to figure out which trait to use while making an action roll related to the given situation.

Have fun, and let the players experience hell!

Chapter 0: Once We Could See the Light

Everything continues as is, while tragedies unfold in distant corners.

This chapter contains four episodes. Each episode narrates a different story, designed to connect the characters' backstories to the main

narrative. Eventually, these are example story frames that could answer the question, “How did the characters end up in Hell?”

The episodes are not consecutive and are independent of each other. These stories don’t even have to take place in the same setting or realm. It is enough for a player to participate in a single episode, and then they can move on to the next chapter.

You could handle these episodes in various ways. Some of the options we suggest are as follows:

- You plan for several sessions, one for each group. You and the players participating in an episode play a separate session apart from other players. Once each player has partaken in an episode, you can continue to Chapter 1.
- During a single session, you take turns with each group that is taking part in different episodes, and carry all of the stories forward at the same time. This requires better planning as it is harder to set the pace for different groups at the same time.
- Your players read the episodes of this chapter. By taking them as a reference, they extend their backstories to tell how they ended up in Hell, at the exact place where this chapter ends. Be careful not to share any crucial information regarding the campaign that might be a spoiler for your players, such as that they are going to Hell.

Although this adventure is designed for four players, and there is an episode for each player, it is up to you and your players how to use them. They could all take part in a single story, combine several episodes into a single one, become bystanders in others’ episodes, or play something else entirely designed by you. The only purpose is to help the players give depth to their characters and guide them towards the main story.

Read this section to your players to introduce them to Character Creation.

Life has its various beauties and numerous challenges. We all struggle to achieve, to find satisfaction. Even through suffering and madness, we strive for the better, for our true selves are made of hope. In our world, even emptiness takes on color in the mind, and even silence carries a sound, for we would not have it otherwise.

What colors adorn your world?

Character Creation

At this point, your players need to create their characters according to the Daggerheart Core Rulebook and any other source you wish to share with them. They will create 1st-level characters.

The characters might be coming from various realms, universes, and realities. If they have contacted the forces of Hell before, or wish to start their journey from the depths where they have been suffering, they can use the content offered in Demonheart during character creation.

As this is a demo adventure and only the demo supplement is available, there are currently few options available to them.

Character Backgrounds

As the players finalize their characters and decide on their backstories, guide them through some questions to decide on their characters’ flaws, past mistakes, regrets, and sins. The following questions might help you.

- Is there any work you left unfinished, and now it bothers you that it is too late to turn back to it?
- Is there a person that you have put your faith in and loved more than they deserved?
- Do you see any dreams that are too euphoric, leaving you depressed throughout the day because you feel like nothing in life could match them?
- When was the last time crying and tears took your breath away out of sadness?

- Have you ever been shunned by society?
- If you could turn back time to a certain point in your life, what would you change?
- Have you ever felt the need to be a better person?
- How would your enemies or haters describe you if they knew you better than you know yourself?
- Do you ever consider dilemmas where you act in the opposite of your character out of self-preservation?
- Do you have any strong opinions on morality, and have you ever questioned your ability to act according to these ideas?
- On the path of vengeance, would you prefer granting a swift death or inflicting torture?
- Have you ever betrayed or been betrayed by someone?
- What is it that you desire most in this life, if you knew there wouldn't be any consequences for achieving it?
- What is your method of derogating the significance of the events you go through?
- What comes to your mind when thinking of escapism - alcohol, drugs, humor, or sex?

After your players decide on their backstories, work together to make slight changes to get the characters into situations that would fit the episode they are going to be a part of. If they won't be a part of the following episodes, or if you choose to handle this act differently, shift the backstories accordingly.

Episode 1: Why Did You Make Me Do This?

It has been a year since the invading forces settled deep within enemy territory. Enduring the winter, far from their homes, they made their point - these lands are not to be surrendered easily. So now, it is time for everyone to take up arms, or else the war is lost.

In this episode, the character will be drafted into the army along with many civilians. They will journey to their posts and fight in the battle. After witnessing the horrors of war, they will be given an impossible choice. It is important to show the ugly face of war rather than glorify it.

The episode takes place in a kingdom called Rolgaria, ruled by King Haspen IV, holding the gilded red banner of a two-headed snake coiled around a birch tree. The enemy nation is the Kingdom of Harvazar, ruled by King Yoderick, holding the green flag of a knotted two-headed snake standing between two lines. If you prefer using a different place, feel free to change the names and symbols throughout the episode.

Act 1: Home

The character experiences the calm of home, knowing nothing of the impending struggle.

Read this section to your player to set the tone for the current consensus.
The weather is grey and damp. The disoriented clouds dot the lazy sky, shaped like flattened popcorn. You wouldn't say that it is raining, but rather occasional drops irk your face. You pull your foot as the mud holds it to the ground, suddenly releasing it with a mushy sound, and take a step. You got everything you needed from the city and are about to arrive back at home. You have been thinking; there hasn't been anything else for you to do since the sun was at its peak. The prices at the market have been increasing while the work pays the same. On top of that, tax collectors now collect grain as well as coins. Even the temple sermons are getting more aggressive. The rumors say conflicts are no longer limited to the border regions, and war is at the door.

As the character approaches their house, let them describe the surrounding area and the house. Detail their descriptions and depict the visual, auditory, and tactile elements to create an immersive experience. As you and the player

build the scenery together, give them chances to roleplay their daily life, emphasizing simple events, such as taking care of their animals, cleaning the house, preparing dinner, lighting a fire, and enjoying quiet time before the hearth. As the character navigates through their life, keep helping them imagine through depictions.

GM Tip! Make sure that the player feels a connection to their home and to people close to them. Don't hesitate to lie to them, claiming that their household will be a prominent part of the adventure and they should carefully consider every detail. Take your time to build that connection and let the character experience a few days, or even months, with time jumps, before continuing.

GM Tip! If you feel extra naughty, ask your player to build a miniature model of their home. Use the model while playing and ensure them that this place will be the headquarters for their future adventures. After the character is taken away from their home, also take away the miniature and give the player a photo of it. Tell them that they will see the miniature again after returning home.

During this period, share the following information with the character through events they experience, people they encounter, rumors they eavesdrop on, and similar methods. This information is designed to give some insight into the world around the character; feel free to add more.

- A group of enemy assassins journeyed deep into the king's territory and attacked a lake mansion. All the staff were killed, and the mansion was burned down. The queen had been going to the lake mansion on vacation every year, but chose not to this year.
- Some merchants disguise themselves as clerics carrying temple artifacts to avoid embargoes.
- A long-time allied kingdom advised that the king should aim for a ceasefire and let go of the lands already invaded. This angered many people, and some claimed that it was a propaganda attempt by enemy spies.
- A gold coin now costs 12 silver coins instead of 10. This inflation caused an increase in the number of treasure hunters and adventurers, and consequently, an increase in fatal accidents.
- The marquis declared mobilization in the border regions. Scouts are also being sent to the inner regions to collect weapons, tools, and metal from towns and villages.
- The invaded land consists of vast lentil farms as well as a prominent outpost, named Sanweary Pavilion, connecting three trade routes.
- A donkey in a nearby village gave birth to a two-headed foal. The priests visited the village to investigate whether any heretical acts took place in this event.

If the character travels during this period, they might encounter wild animals around the road, inquisitively guarding their territory, such as a pack of **Dire Wolves** watching from afar or a **Bear** fishing in the river. If they travel to small settlements, there could be **Archer Guards**, **Bladed Guards**, or a **Head Guard** around. If the character chooses to visit a big town or a city, they could also come across **Cortiers**, **Merchants**, and **Petty Nobles**. Feel free to add some monstrous creatures to the journey as you see fit.

Act 2: Recruitment

A group of soldiers comes to the settlement where the character lives or is visiting, to acquire weapons, tools, food, medicine, vinegar, and metal for the war effort. However, they are also drafting civilians to join the fight.

The group is led by Commander Archus Orsmit, a **Knight of the Realm**. He is a tall, middle-aged man with a tired face and dark, beady eyes, inquisitively combing around. He is wearing a green linen leg covering and a red padded jacket, which seem to be the underlayers of full plate armor. There are sticks tied to his back and head with cloth strips, stopping him from turning his head; he stands awkwardly upright on his horse because of this. He has recently hit a tree while riding the horse and injured himself, and as a

makeshift solution to protect his spine, he is fastened to the sticks.

A **War Wizard** *(Kayleen gav Highton; young adult; everything she says feels slightly like she is whining, although it's her normal speech; she repeats everything at least twice as she believes no one gets her the first time)* and a **Spy** *(Trav Hamilton; middle-aged; he can talk about the saddest moment with a smile and a joyous occasion with a frown; he believes that nothing is outside his scope and he always has something to contribute in all kinds of situations)* are accompanying the knight. They are followed by a handful of **Elite Soldiers** as well as two **Archer Squadrons** and over forty **Conscripts**. Everyone looks tired from weeks of travel, but the conscripts seem especially exhausted and hopeless. Apart from the horses of the knight, wizard, and spy, ten horses are ridden in turn by the exhausted soldiers, and six horses pull three carts full of supplies. Most are wearing tabards, and some are holding banners.

After setting the scene, read this section to your player.
The military crowd settles around the knight, trying to rest their legs by lying and sitting down wherever they can find a spot. The knight turns around on his horse, meeting the gazes of the curious bystanders. He speaks with a weary but loud voice. "*Mayhall Hills and the Snake Valley are lost. We are losing the war, and the enemy is on their way. They aren't coming because of a dispute in politics or a necessity born out of an honorable idea. They aren't coming with gifts, with peace offerings in their bloodied hands. They are coming to take, and they don't care from whom they take.* *The army protected your homes, lands, your loved ones, and your wealth. They have done so while asking for little. They died and even now, they are giving up their last breaths on the front. It is now your time to stand up for yourselves. It is now your time to serve and give your life, so the rest will live on. Make peace with everyone you are leaving behind, as overmorrow, we march for them.*

If there is a crowd, one person will try to run away. An archer will shoot them from the back of their head, and the arrow will pierce their skull, coming out of the eye socket, rupturing the eye, and causing it to come out. The person drops to the ground, starts convulsing in shock, and moans in agonal breathing. The knight shouts in the most authoritative voice he can muster, "TREASON WILL NOT BE TOLERATED!" The wounded person will survive, forever crippled, unable to form coherent thoughts ever again.

At this point, the character has been drafted into the army. If there are other people around, some of them have also been drafted. The character has 2 days to bid farewell to their home and loved ones. If they try to escape, the soldiers catch them, beat them, and tie them to each other and then to a post.

GM Tip! If the character has loved ones staying with them or near them, don't draft them to the army. Separating them is more stressful for the character. However, also drafting them and killing them in the war is another sweet option.

Let the character spend their last two days. At the dawn of the second day, they depart with the soldiers.

Act 3: Journey

The road to the front takes around two weeks. The band follows a path along the mountainside to be able to see the terrain below, while a scouting party follows from the summit to stay alert against ambushes. They walk almost the entire day, except for rests to eat and sleep.

The first couple of days, they journey through fields and forests to reach the mountain, and take another day to climb it. After that, the majority of the path goes through clear mountainside without any tall plants and trees, dotted with bare rocks. Throughout the journey, the mountain shifts into a hill, covered in dense foliage and forest, hard to tread because of the ups and downs and roots covered in a carpet of fallen leaves.

The band is in an awful state. They take turns keeping watch and sleep in torn bedrolls on the ground without tents. The food is tasteless and consists mostly of hard bread, dried meat, and raisins. The water is muddy with a bitter taint, making it harder to wash down the dry food. Many have swelling and blisters on their feet,

and the risk of rot rises with each day. Because of the conditions, the character starts each day by **marking a Stress**.

The character might identify beneficial herbs (Difficulty 13) during the journey and collect them. Using these herbs, the character might prepare tea with a calming effect (Difficulty 13), ointments for the blisters (Difficulty 14), and use them in food to give it some taste (Difficulty 15). Any of these would increase the morale of a creature if used on it, and such a creature doesn't need to **mark a Stress** at the start of the day; this increase in morale lasts a day for the tea, two days for the ointment, and three days for the aroma.

GM Tip! Fill this section with a wide variety of NPCs, after all, the conscripts are gathered from different regions. Let them talk and interact with the character, even in meaningless exchanges. Consider that most people tend to talk about the same topics over and over again each day. Make the journey long and boring, detailing every day and every camp. Describe the scenery, although it rarely changes due to the band's slow pace.

The following are example NPCs that you might want to use as conscripts.

- Valdick. He is a young adult of slender build. He has no nose or upper lip, as if they were cut. He lost them to a disease, and the same disease claimed his wife and son. An apprentice wizard found him on the brink of death and treated him with honey and moldy food. All the speech he can muster comes as wheezing breath and fluting consonants leaking through wet flesh. He loves the sound and smell of the rain but hates getting wet.
- Andy. He is a short teen with a moderate build and a slightly hunched posture. A couple of years ago, his older sister was kidnapped by bandits who also killed their grandfather, who tried to fight back as their parents weren't at home. Several months later, she was rescued by the king's rangers and returned, although she was not the same. After the incident, Andy became bitter and always angry. He shows respect and demands respect in return. He hates sexual jokes and anyone who tries to shame women. He was taken out of prison to be drafted into the army; the crime was stabbing a group of men who were insulting a prostitute.
- Clarissa. She is a young and charismatic groom. She stands short with short curly hair reaching just under her ears. Years ago, a horse she was taking care of kicked her husband in the leg, leaving him with a limp. As he was not suitable to join the army, she volunteered to take his place. The husband is an official who earns good money, so she believes that their three children would be better off with their dad, and she needs to fight against the invading forces to protect her family. She handles a commotion especially well.

While passing by a hut nestled into the rocky slope of the forest, three teenagers, siblings, emerge and begin yelling at the soldiers, swearing and cursing at them (*They hate the king and his soldiers because their parents were merchants and were unjustly executed by the order of the king, on the grounds that they supplied goods to enemy civilians*). The band ignores them at first, but then one of the teenagers shouts, "Do you let your king fuck you however he chooses?" (*The character sees that it is the youngest sibling who said it*). The commander halts the band and signals the soldiers to capture the teens. They rush toward them and, after a short brawl, drag all three before the commander. He asks which of them insulted the king; they refuse to answer. He orders the execution of all three for treason. The soldiers draw their swords as the teenagers begin begging for their lives and apologizing.

- If the character steps up for the teens, the commander asks them to give up the one who insulted the king, claiming that they will execute only the one who did it. The eldest sibling takes the blame and is executed.
- If the character says that it was the youngest sibling, the youngest sibling is executed. The looks of the other two, locked on the character, raging with

hatred and disgust, will never leave the character's mind.
- If the character chooses not to interfere, all three are executed.

After the event is resolved, the spy turns to the commander and says, "We have been encountering rebels too often lately; it is troubling," hinting that they have done this before, more than once. Then, they continue on their way as if nothing had even happened.

Eventually, the tree line mingling with the rugged hill retreats, and the band arrives at their destination: on the edge of an escarpment looking over a steppe.

Act 4: War

There is a river cutting through the steppes, and an army stands on each side. The closer side is decorated with red banners, while the enemy side is filled with green patches. There are over five thousand enemy forces, while there are only around two thousand allied forces.

While the character stands at the edge and looks out over the steppes, read this section to your player.

The sky is clear, and the hills cast their shortest shadows. Before the grand scenery, there is a dark, meandering river dividing the grassland, reaching out to the horizon. White tents are on both sides, one holding gilded red banners, the other adorned with dark-edged green ones.

Archus has donned his layers of steel plate and, with Kayleen, stands at the edge. He shouts a command, "*Form a line before the wizard!*" As you get in line before the cliff, the wizard touches her staff to the first soldier, murmuring arcane syllables. The soldier jumps and slowly glides down, becoming a dot in the distance. One by one, with the wizard's magical guidance, the band descends from the escarpment.

As you touch the ground, you hear a thud and an ugly crunch nearby. You snap your gaze toward the sound and see a body shattered under its own weight, broken bones rending the flesh. Right after, Kayleen sets her feet on a nearby rock, looks at you, and claims without concern, "Sometimes spells fail," and walks away.

Choose the NPC who is going to fall to their death, considering the character's relations with them.

The band walks for half a day towards the camp on compact soil and dry grass, crunching beneath each step. They arrive at the camp at night. Everyone in the camp is busy with something, soldiers going back and forth, creating uncertainty for onlookers who have no idea what is going on. A lieutenant assigns everyone a tent and informs them that the battle will commence at dawn.

While the character walks around the camp, they encounter two **Elite Soldiers** taking a woman in shackles to a tent while she is screaming at the top of her lungs, crying. If the character confronts them, they say, "She is an enemy spy. Her interrogation is finished, and now she is to be executed. We will have some fun before wasting such beauty." Meanwhile, the woman begs for help.

- If the character kills the woman, the soldiers will get angry but won't do anything physical. After all, she was to be executed.
- If the character attacks the soldiers, start a standard countdown (3). When the countdown ends, backup arrives, and they beat the character senseless. The character will be taken to their tent, unconscious, and join the battle in shackles.
- If the character fails to act and the soldiers take the woman to the tent, she escapes shortly after, running outside. While holding a knife with both hands, she yells, "I invoke Eugon! Hell be upon you all! Your babies shall drown in their mothers' blood!" and slits her own throat.

Eugon is one of the lords of the seven deadly sins: The Sinlord of Wrath.

The character gets an opportunity to eat a proper hot stew and rest in a bedroll within a tent. The rest of the scene is up to the GM's discretion. Consider including soldiers who are praying for a safe return from tomorrow's battle, some sitting in silence and contemplating their choices, a few enjoying the night with laughs as if there were no tomorrow, and others trying to ease their minds through labor followed by sleep.

When the sun rises, and it is dawn, read this section to your player.

You wake to the echoing sound of horns and step out of the tent. Soldiers rush toward you, just as they do to the others, dressing you in chainmail and handing you a sword. It feels like any other day: the sun is up, the sky is clear, the crickets are chirping, and the birds are circling... the world does not seem to care, after all.

Before any worry can settle in, the rush begins. The flow of soldiers pulls you out of the camp, placing you before the ranks. The vast steppe lies ahead of you, and thousands stand beside you. Officers run across the lines relaying orders. "Archers!", "Form ranks!", "Shields to the front!", "Third and fourth cavalry to the southern hill!" You become aware of your breathing and feel compelled to control it manually. The banners begin to rise on both sides, coloring the battlefield.

Then... silence.

The distant silhouettes, blurred by the wavering air, take position before the river. One by one, they begin to cross it.

The enemy forces secured the river with their archers, using their numerical superiority. Their troops are crossing one by one, and the allied forces are outside the archers' range.

GM Tip! Take your time depicting the war. The battlefield is vast, and it takes time for troops to move into position. Things move slowly; set the pace accordingly.

The war plays out in several parts. Not all soldiers charge each other at the same time, and many of them don't want to die a meaningless death. No group rushes into the enemy lines recklessly; they secure a line and engage.

1. As the enemy forces try to form ranks across the river, a group of heavily plated, shield-bearing soldiers advances toward them. The first wave of arrows strikes them, with most deflected by their armor, though some find their mark. The group retreats, dragging their wounded back with them.
2. Another group of heavily armored soldiers, accompanied by a squadron of archers, advances toward the enemy. They attempt to return fire but are overwhelmed by the response. After several successful hits, they too retreat.
3. Several archer squadrons and groups of spearmen are dispatched toward a northern point along the river, beyond the enemy archers' range. While they do so, the allied army begins advancing toward the enemy, as the commanders can now accurately determine the enemy's range.
4. Half of the enemy army has crossed the river. Distant battle horns sound from the southern hill, and several banners are raised. The third and fourth cavalry squadrons have crossed the river at the southern hill and are now advancing toward the enemy army from the opposite side. During their fast approach, they set off several rune traps, which exploded and scattered the shattered pieces of horses and their riders around.
5. The war wizards cast a spell, sending crackling lightning across the cavalry's route and triggering the traps before any more riders could step on them. However, the enemy had already crossed the riverfront, and now they began their advance. Shields at the front, followed by minor illusionists veiling the battlefield in misdirecting mist, and behind them marched mostly swordsmen and spearmen. The enemy cavalry began advancing toward the northern point where the allied forces had started to cross.
6. After the enemy front line had advanced close enough for arrow volleys to become dangerous for both sides, the

order came from the flanks, and the allied army began advancing beyond the secure line. The character now approaches the inevitable, losing sight of the greater picture as the focus begins to shift toward the enemy ahead.

7. The enemy archers release several waves of arrows toward the far rear lines, avoiding their own troops, though most are deflected by the firecracker spells of the casters, shattering the arrows mid-flight. The enemy is now only a sprint away, and everyone has fallen into tunnel vision, focused solely on the enemy ahead.

At this point, the character is getting closer to the enemy line, and both sides start to pick up the pace, turning into a sprint. The battle continues across the field, but the character is too busy with their own survival, stuck within the chaos; they can't comprehend what is going on.

As both sides are about to clash, read this section to your player.

You instinctively hold your breath, and the thunderous steps of thousands drown out every other sound. Although the confrontation is imminent, each step takes longer than the last to land; it feels as though the moment will never arrive. Yet... it does. Metal striking metal, flesh being torn apart, screams and shouts. You are no longer moving on your own, but being squeezed, pulled, and shoved from all sides. Your knees give out, but you muster every bit of strength you can to remain standing, for falling would mean being trampled to death.

Your body is overwhelmed by a cold sensation. You cannot even reach the enemy, so you pathetically yell and shout, waving your weapon with one arm while the other is trapped within a sea of armor and shields. You feel as though you are drowning on dry land; your peripheral vision darkens and narrows. You keep forcing breath into your lungs, but the drowning never ceases. After some time, which feels like lifetimes to you, the formation breaks and both sides begin to spill past one another. Before you know it, a brute clad in an enemy tabard stands before you.

It is time for the character to fight their way out. The Fast-Paced Actions rule is designed to create a quick-paced feeling in this fight. Feel free to ignore it if it doesn't suit your taste, although we strongly advise giving it a try.

At the beginning of the fight, start with a simple encounter, such as a **Sellsword**, and gradually increase the challenge as the character defeats their enemies. At first, increase the number of weaker encounters, then include stronger adversaries. The following list is an example of adversary choices for this fight, increasing in power as you go down the list.

- 1 **Sellsword**
- 1 **Sellsword**
- 1 **Sellsword**
- 1 **Sellsword**
- 2 **Sellswords**
- 2 **Sellswords**
- 2 **Conscripts**
- 3 **Conscripts**
- 1 **Weaponmaster** (has 2 HP)
- 1 **Elite Soldier** (has 2 HP)
- 2 **Elite Soldiers** (each has 2 HP)
- 1 **Knight of the Realm** (has 3 HP)
- 2 **Elite Soldiers**
- 2 **Knights of the Realm**

The combat ends after the character marks all HP and falls to the ground, half-unconscious. Afterwards, the fight retreats to another position, leaving the character lying on the crushed, pierced, butchered, and battered corpses. Upon looking toward the bloodied battlefield, the character realizes they cannot tell the banners apart, soaked in blood; in the end, they all look the same. And the character loses consciousness.

Fast-Paced Actions

Each player holds thrice the amount of d12 dice they would normally roll. The GM describes a situation, such as "*A tabardless soldier holding a knife is running toward you, but you can't tell which side they are on.*" Immediately after, all players roll the dice onto the same place on the table. The GM takes away any d12s rolled from the table each second until a player decides on an

action. Upon deciding on an action, the player can grab any two d12s from the table and consider the total of their result the result of the action roll. If a player can't secure any dice, their action roll fails.

If you want to up the pace, you could reduce the number of dice held by the players before the roll to twice the amount they would normally roll.

Act 5: Judgement

Although the character isn't aware of it yet, they are dead.

Read this section to your player.
You narrow your eyes, trying to fight against your eyelids pulling themselves shut. You blink feverishly and finally force your eyes open. It hurts... everywhere. You can feel your heartbeat across your skin, and it feels as though there are lumps within your body that you want to claw open and tear apart. You are in pain and discomfort, and everything aches with each movement. It is the dark blue night of a full moon. You stand up. There is no one. You hear the flutter of loose fabric from the abandoned tents. The breeze whistles through the hollows of deformed armor. The smell of the battlefield has already settled, giving way to the scent of the cold, damp night. You have survived, and it is finally over. Yet... why do you hear the clank of metal and the sound of hoofbeats behind you?

When the character turns around, they see Archus Orsmith, fully armored and armed, sitting on his horse. Although the character isn't aware, this is actually an entity judging the soul of the character. He lets out words in a calm voice, "Have I a reward for you? Have you felled your foes? Have you enacted doctrine? Have you shown virtue? In what manner have you wielded your sword? Answer me these!"

It is up to you to decide on the sins of the character and judge them accordingly. Regardless of the severity of their sins, the character will be condemned to Hell, so you could be a little hypocritical and judgmental towards the character.

Judge of Souls (shaped like Archus) attacks the character, shouting, "Have you sinned?" The character has all of his HP and Stress cleared.

- The Judge of Souls can't use its Deny Earthly Possession action if the character stood up for the person shot by an archer for refusing to join the military.
- The Judge of Souls can't use its Disharmonizing Crescent action if the character tried their best to save the teenagers who insulted the king from execution.
- The Judge of Souls can't use its Trample action if the character did their best to save the spy being taken away by two guards in the camp.

The judge asks questions in archaic speech with every action it takes, trying to force the character to confess their sins. The judge isn't trying to kill the character quickly; instead, the judge is trying to judge the character's soul through this combat. Although the judge wouldn't abstain from harming, crippling, and torturing the character.

JUDGE OF SOULS (ARCHUS)

Tier 4 Solo
A cosmic entity that judges souls, sending them to their appropriate afterlives.
Motives & Tactics: Confession, overpower, judge

Difficulty: 20 | **Threshold:** 25/52 | **HP:** 12 | **Stress:** 14
ATK: +6 | **Longsword:** Melee | 4d10+12 phy

Experience: Cosmology +4, Morality +4, Logic +4

FEATURES

Anticipated Image - ***Passive:*** The judge appears different to each creature, taking form according to their judgment.
Deny Earthly Possession - ***Action:*** The judge rips apart a piece, such as an armor, scale, horn, or skin, from a creature within Melee range. **Spend 2 Fear** and permanently reduce the Damage

Thresholds of the creature by 1d4 (to a minimum of 1). This effect can only be removed by a level 8 or more powerful healing effect.
Disharmonizing Crescent - ***Action:*** The judge swings its weapons, shooting a crescent-shaped purple force. **Spend 3 Fear** to make an attack against a creature within Far range. On a success, the crescent severs one of the creature's limbs, and the creature **marks a HP**.
Trample - ***Action:*** While mounted, the judge can charge towards a creature smaller than the mount, trample the creature, and continue its movement. **Spend a Fear,** and the creature marks an Armor Slot, a HP, and a Stress.
Grab Weapon - ***Reaction:*** When a creature makes an attack with a weapon from Melee range, the judge can **spend a Fear** to grab the weapon, take it away from the creature's hands, and toss it anywhere within close range.

After the judgment has passed, the Judge of Souls strikes to kill. The Judge yells the verdict on the character's soul, such as, "You have sinned gravely!" or "Heavy are your sins!" before striking the final blow. If the character hasn't committed any sins but was too powerless to stop others from committing them, the Judge might say something like "Weakness is a sin!" Although the Judge never speaks about Heaven or Hell. The character wakes up from the vision the moment they are killed.

Upon waking, the character finds themself passed out on the battlefield. The battle is long concluded, and the invading forces have been defeated. It is up to the GM's discretion how to handle the losses and the aftermath of the war. However, the character eventually returns home.

It is, again, up to the GM's discretion on how long the way back should take. However, after the character arrives back home, give them at least 10 to 20 minutes to process the things that happened and settle back in.

Unfortunately, the character had never returned, and it is still a part of the vision, but they'll never know. While describing the home, casually describe an additional door in the house, even though it wasn't there in the first place. Make the player second-guess themselves.

Read this section to your player while the character spends time at home.
You left, and you came back. Nothing changed. Maybe you did. The moment you stepped back into your home, every bad memory began to feel like a fever dream. All you had to do was wake up... and you did. But you wonder. How many doors were there in your house?

As the character approaches the door, someone knocks on the other side.

Proceed to Chapter 1.

Episode 2: The Constellation Of The Dead

The most ancient of rituals were conducted on the days of recurring magical tides. The scholars, mystics, and theurgists of their time charted these occurrences by the state of the heavens. Ever since, the pursuers of the occult have been trying to unearth these forgotten methodologies and use them to their benefit. And the stars have aligned.

In this episode, the character will be investigating a rumor about ritual resurrection, hoping to bring back a loved one. While pursuing the leads throughout the region, they will get into an accident and be rescued by an old lady. After a long recovery and learning that the ritual will take place inside a nearby temple, the character will continue the chase, only to meet with betrayal.

The episode takes place in Maple Valley, where maple trees paint the gentle incline red. The tranquil river patiently carves a path through the red clay floodplain. A hillside path goes through the eastern side of the valley, connecting three villages. These villages are known for their kilns, clay, charcoal, pottery, and pearl enchantments.

Act 1: Accident

The character had been searching for a way to revive a loved one when they came across the rumors of Maple Valley. Apart from having amazing scenery, the valley was the birthplace of many stories, nursery rhymes, and odd superstitions about rebreathing the gift of life. One such nursery rhyme goes like this:

"Nose, nose, find me those,
I smell someone close.
Ear, ear, hear me clear,
Don't trust the bony seer.
Eye, eye, won't you cry,
A second chance is nearby.
Mouth, mouth, the lying mouth,
Please deny the evil route.
Heart, heart, the demon heart,
Remain dead and stay apart."

When the character arrives at the Maple Valley on a warm morning, read this section to your player.
Green-to-red-hued leaves saturate the ground, while those remaining on the branches paint the open sky like a canvas with the same sunset palette. Maple trees cover both hillsides, divided by the floodplain of earthy red. A gentle river, ankle-deep, carves a path through clay; crystal clear in the middle, swirly whirlpools of mud along the edges. There lies a sunken road ahead, a stretched balcony facing the opposite slope towards your left, with vined branches as overhangs and earthen mounds as railings.

The road leads to the first village in the valley after a twelfth-of-a-day hike. The valley curves around the river, hiding the villages behind its maple-dense walls. There was currently heavy rainfall, followed by a flood, which damaged parts of the road and destabilized the terrain.

GM Tip! If the character can fly, think of creative ways to hinder them. They need to traverse this path. A wound from a former battle might keep them from flying, as well as a wing spasm, getting hit by a skipping rock from a rockslide, or simply strong winds. Don't force it too obviously and stress the player - we don't want them to know what we are after.

Shortly after the character takes the road, a wet fawn-colored dog walks towards them, skipping, seemingly smiling. The dog passes by the character and continues in the opposite direction. The character can persuade the dog to follow them instead (Difficulty 9). The dog normally hangs around the village but got stuck on this side of the road.

The continuous treeline is disrupted by a set of bushes a while after. These plants have batches of tiny reds and dark purples swarming their stems, which are elderberries (Difficulty 10). Elderberries are mostly cooked before eating, as eating them raw might cause nausea (Difficulty 11).

Halfway toward the first village, the road abruptly ends. The hillside bends towards the road and blocks the way with a long, steep cliff. A makeshift wooden walkway clings to the cliff, jutting out over the river below, at a height slightly taller than a maple tree. It is supported by beams inserted into the cliff and fastened by suspension ropes from above. Beyond the walkway, the road resumes toward the village. The walkway appears damaged, and there are entire sections missing.

The dog won't come near the walkway as it is afraid of the height. The character can climb over the cliff (Difficulty 15) or try to jump over the missing sections on the walkway: first section (Difficulty 10), second section (Difficulty 13), and third section (Difficulty 20). Failure on any of these rolls means that the character falls from the cliff, down to the floodplain.

If the character falls, read this section to your player.
You slip, and for a moment, your body takes control in an attempt to save itself. You try to cling to the branches and roots, but the force dislocates your shoulder and slashes your fingers. You desperately try to brace yourself against the sharp, steep rocks, but the impact twists and breaks your leg. A shallow gasp empties what little breath remains in your lungs. The world spins and stops in an instant as you plummet into the clay, severely injured and buried halfway within it. You can't move, and the pain starts to seep into your flesh.

Now you understand, nature might appear beautiful, but it is impartial.

The cold of the shock slowly leaves your body, and the heat of the pain takes its place. The clouds drift through the valley, and the birds continue chirping. (If the dog accompanied the character) The only concern you can hear of is your new friend barking over the cliff.

After the character falls and becomes unconscious, continue to Act 2.

If the character successfully passes the obstacle, they will see a fox hiding in the foliage under the trees. The fox stares at the character, and the character can't look away from its eyes for a moment, and they are overwhelmed with a weird feeling. As the GM, take note of this moment; during a critical moment where the character would die, let them see the fox nearby, and they will be saved through sheer luck. Use this later in the following chapters.

After seeing the fox, the character continues its way. Read this section to your player.

You round a right turn as the first village reveals itself in the distance, nestled within a sloped grove. Several wooden cabins dot the cliffside face of the settlement. Earthen steps layer upon one another, carpeted in tall grain grasses and delineated by wooden fences stretching alongside the road that curves upward into the village center. Thin smoke from hearths and kilns swirls upward, and below, specks of people wander about.

On the nearer side of the road, five figures stare at you as they draw closer. They are a hundred steps away, give or take. Adorned in frayed cloth and cracked leather accessories, their worn visages inspire no good feelings within you, and the arsenal of daggers, clubs, and hand axes they carry certainly does not help.

Five bandits are coming toward the character. They have just stolen from the villagers, carrying 1 to 2 bags of gold, some personal items of the villagers (taken as souvenirs), and an oil painting of a young woman petting a clay rabbit (on canvas, cut from its frame). A **jagged knife kneebreaker** carries the loot in a sack, and four **jagged knife bandits** accompany him. There is a **jagged knife sniper** following them from the woods, trying to stay *Hidden*.

The bandits will try to mug the character and take everything they have except for clothes. They can be reasoned with to some degree, but they will try to take everything from the character regardless. If the character takes hostile actions against the bandits, tries to escape, or resists in any way, they will beat and stab the character and leave the almost lifeless body on the side of the road.

If the character successfully handles the encounter and continues their way, their luck is spent and something terrible is going to happen. The character is going to be incapacitated or severely wounded before they can get to the village. There could be a landslide, collapsing the road down to the river, a monster might attack, or the weapons of the bandits could have been coated in poison, and it starts to take effect. This is due to the character approaching their supernatural, diabolic doom.

Act 2: Recovery

Some time after the accident, a group of villagers finds the unconscious character and brings them to the village. If the dog is alive and somewhere near the character, they also bring the dog back.

Before the character wakes up, check out the details of the village and the villagers. It is up to you, the GM, on how long and detailed this act will be. Feel free to make changes, add and remove NPCs, places, details, and shape the village to fit into your narrative.

Layout of the Village. The village is settled upon a slope surrounded by maple trees, its houses and cabins built from maple wood. It stretches from the cliffside overlooking the river to the nooks of the forest, constructed upon narrow plains layered atop one another like giant steps. There are nearly a couple of dozen houses, along with their gardens, farms, common buildings, and workshops. The most prominent structures are the grain storage, cellar, inn, kiln garden, paint workshop, pottery workshop, and knife house.

Within the cellar, large earthen pots line wooden shelves, filled with maple syrup, grain wine, and vinegar, sealed with leather covers. The kiln garden is a flattened stretch of soil bordered by a wooden fence, housing the six major kilns of the village and a small depot filled with tar and charcoal. The inn is a simple building with an open kitchen built around a hearth, where boiling stews are served in heated earthenware bowls. The paint workshop contains several simple tools and materials, such as cauldrons, mortars and pestles, brushes, fine powders, dried herbs, and insects; a chicken coop stands adjacent to the building.

The two most important buildings are the pottery workshop and the knife house. The pottery workshop is divided into workstations by knee-high brick walls. Many tools rest upon low tables within these sections, such as needles, brushes, wooden shaping tools, scissors, and paddles. The knife house is a small cabin crowded with wood-handled precision tools, as well as numerous cloths, alchemical liquids, and herbs. It is so full of tools that only a single person can fit inside at a time. The knife house is where a crafter carves runes into pearls and anoints them with special mixtures.

Livelihood. Except for houses, gardens, and farms, the land and buildings have no owners; the villagers use them collectively. Everyone takes part in agriculture to meet the basic needs of the village, such as feed, food, and fiber. They also fish in the river and hunt crabs. The villagers' main diet consists of bread, meat stew with grains and root vegetables, milk, wine, pickles, and maple syrup.

Most elders are masters of a craft, mainly pottery and pearl enchantment, though also including weavers, breadmakers, blacksmiths, and paintsmiths. They sell these products to travelers and sometimes send them in batches to cities through merchants. Master-apprentice relationships are very important in the village, and the craftsmen work hard to educate the younger generation.

Pearl Enchantment

The art of carving symbols and runes connected through lines and shapes is called pearl enchantment. It is a meticulous craft focused on extremely fine detail. These pearls are also anointed with oils and alchemical substances to give them a characteristic shine and scent; they are polished with special cloths and mineral powders to achieve a smooth texture. Every enchanted pearl possesses a different aspect, such as luck, peace, or wealth, which people believe is invoked by carrying the pearl on one's person.

Villagers. The following are some characters from the village.

- Ikhon is an elderly man living by himself in the far corner of the village. He was a smuggler in his youth and moved to this village shortly after marrying Miri, a woman from a neighboring village, following an argument with her parents. Up until his wife's passing twelve years ago, they were active members of the community and mainly dabbled in agriculture. Nowadays, he looks after a chicken coop, wanders along the cliffside to catch the sun, and rarely participates in village events. He has over a dozen cats in and around his house because his wife loved them and wanted him to show the same affection toward animals. He is not grumpy or bitter, but every aching bone in his body makes it difficult for him to enjoy each passing moment. He likes playing the flute.
- Nana Helga is an elderly woman who spent her early life in the city. Her parents were merchants, and they made sure Helga received the best education they could provide. She began her career as an herbalist and later became an apothecary. She had a husband, three children, and a granddaughter. After divorcing her husband, as there was no love left between them, Helga left the city and moved to this village to clear her head. She has been part of the community ever since. Over the years, she learned the art of paintmaking and now teaches the younger generation. As she earned a considerable amount of

money during her life in the city and made wise investments, she has not needed to work since moving to the village; instead, she spends her time pursuing arts and crafts.

- Brandon is the middle-aged potter responsible for operating and maintaining the kilns. His father and grandmother were also potters, from whom he learned the craft. He still lives with them, taking care of his elders. Brandon is a handsome man with a muscular build who also earns good money. People from surrounding villages often come to meet him, claiming they wish to learn pottery, though many are simply trying to flirt with him. However, he is so devoted to his art that he never returns the same affection to his suitors. He likes to drink during his free time.
- Gigi is the daughter of Ronald the farmer, and Gina the fisher. She has a pet duck named Mini that follows her everywhere. The duck attacks anyone who gets too close to Gigi. She is a child full of love and curiosity. She hates eating fish because removing the bones is difficult.

After the character passes out, a group of teenagers from the village finds and carries them back to the settlement. They bring the character to an elderly woman, Gran Yngy, who immediately begins tending to the wounds. The character will slowly regain consciousness over a couple of days, but they will be severely wounded and crippled, unable to leave the bed for weeks, and the village for months.

Yngy takes care of the character during this period, cleaning the wounds, cooking meals, and helping with movement. She is a caring person with a soft heart. She always smells of pleasant spices and flour. Because of the loss she suffered, helping people overcome dire conditions is important to Gran. She is also a religious person, praying to the gods and goddesses for the safety of others. Although very old, Yngy still takes care of everything around the house, and she possesses incomparable experience when it comes to self-sufficiency in a village.

Gran Yngy has a spacious house built by her late son, Brick. It has a cellar, a small barn, two rooms, a living room, and a mezzanine floor above it. The character stays in the living room, in a bed made of stacked quilts before the fireplace. One of the rooms is empty, while the other belongs to Gran. The cellar is filled with goods necessary to survive the winter, and there are two pigs in the barn. A ladder leads up to the mezzanine floor, where she stores fabrics and dried products.

Gran's son, Brick, was a veteran who returned home severely traumatized. He suffered from nightmares and panic attacks. He drank excessively, got into fights, stole, and abused drugs. Most of the time, he was angry; the rest of the time, melancholic. One night, years ago, he committed suicide by cutting his wrists and lying down in the river. Gran awoke at midnight with a dreadful feeling, found Brick's room empty, and went searching for him, only to discover his corpse in the river. She blames herself for the death of her son, and she refuses to speak about anything regarding this subject.

The following are some details regarding Brick. Gran never speaks about this, so it is up to the character to acquire this information.

- There is an empty leather pouch embroidered with a daisy buried in the garden, adjacent to the barn. This pouch was Gran’s, and Brick stole it for drug money. The daisy represents the daisy fields where Gran’s husband asked her hand in marriage.
- Gran keeps all knives in her room, hidden inside a small box, placed under her bed. She becomes anxious seeing other people holding knives, as Brick used to threaten people and eventually took his own life with them.
- On the first day of each week, Gran bakes a maple custard pie. When asked about it, she becomes nostalgic and avoids giving a clear answer while trying to hold back her tears. It was the only day Brick behaved properly, because he loved the pie so much that his mood remained stable throughout the day.

- The empty room was Brick's room. Although it was cleaned and emptied, there is a fist-sized redish ooze on the window stool. It is a magical item previously owned by Brick, known as a jot. It was a gift from a fellow soldier who died in battle.

Brick's Jot
A jot is a magical item shaped like an ooze, having a large mouth resembling a human's. When you place it on your shoulder, it becomes active and starts insulting people whenever you feel like it. It uses your mannerisms and knowledge to weave together insults.

This specific jot had remained attuned to Brick for a long time, and it still carries the remnants of his insults. It might weave awkward comments about self-harm into the insults. For example: "I would cut my feet off rather than being in your shoes" or "Kill yourself to save your loved ones from tolerating you, you horse fucking bandit."

The character can learn the following during their stay in the village.

- The villagers salt the grave after burial to stop the dead from rising.
- Zoe, the pearl enchanter, carves a unique design known as Akerika. It is believed that Akerika pearls make one invisible to evil spirits and turn the bearer into a beacon for the spirits of loved ones, allowing them to find their way back.
- People tap their bowls with their spoons before beginning a meal. They believe it awakens the dead, allowing departed loved ones to join them at the table.
- There are old temple ruins high in the mountains, a week's walk away. Shady figures gather there at times, though they never descend to the villages.
- Leia, the huntress, sometimes ventures to the ruins to scout the area. She sees wannabe cultists attempting spells before the broken altars, all to no avail.
- Amy, the paintmaker, is known for creating unique shades of white, gray, and green using human remains. A brilliant shade of green paint she created is known as Lich's Eyes.
- An adventuring necromancer passed through the village several seasons ago and remarked, "This is the most beautiful view and the freshest air I have ever breathed."
- There is a myth about a maple fae that grants wishes whenever lightning strikes a maple tree, splitting it apart and setting it aflame. These wishes are said to be so powerful that they can bring about the downfall of empires, reverse the setting of the sun, and make the hearts of the dead beat once more.

GM Tip! Do not reveal these pieces of information too quickly. Let the character uncover them slowly through their own investigation. Add personal dramas, baseless opinions, and confusing relationships to distract the character. Include irrelevant anecdotes to shift the focus and make the player question which lead is truly important. Do not reveal these pieces of information too quickly. Let the character uncover them slowly through their own investigation. Add personal dramas, baseless opinions, and confusing relationships to distract the character. Include irrelevant anecdotes to shift the focus and make the player question which lead is truly important.

Act 3: Resurrection

After months of recovery, when the character has almost regained their strength, a group of adventurers arrives at the village. There are at least four people, and you can create and use any 2-level character for them.

They have recently raided a cultist hideout and found a letter about organizing a ritual intended to call forth a soul and bless it with a body. The letter also mentioned the ruins on these mountains. The adventurers have followed the leads and find themselves here, and now, they are preparing to go to the mentioned ruins. The ritual can only take place once every 133 years, when the stars align. The stars will align, and the cultists will attempt the ritual within the week. This is the chance the character is looking for.

The adventurers' goal is to kill the cultists, as they have committed numerous crimes, including crimes against them. They don't care about the ritual. One of their team members was also killed by such a cultist, so it is also about revenge.

Gran Yngy wants to join the adventurers to make sure they travel safely to the ruins, but deep down, she is hoping for a second chance with her son. Even if the character passes on this opportunity, Gran will take it and go with them. Even without the character, the rest of the act plays out, and Gran makes her deal, condemning the character to Hell.

If the character joins the adventurers, they will travel for a week to the ruins through the forest. Even if the character doesn't let Yngy join them, she will follow them from a distance, without being noticed. Eventually, they will arrive at the location.

When the character arrives at the scene, read this section to your player.

The ritual chamber lies in the ruined temple of a once-glorious Sun God. The air is wet, yet unnaturally warm. Scents of burnt resin, blood, and old incense attack your nerves. In the chamber, there are pillars decorated with different depictions of the sun. However, they are painted with blood and tar, and resemble screaming faces.

At the center of the chamber, a massive obsidian disk rests, and on it, spiraling infernal glyphs are carved. 8 legs protrude from the disk like the legs of a spider, serving as a table for 8 ritual masters.

Ritual masters are waiting for the Dark Hour, during which Hell is closer to the world than Heaven. They are wearing robes of different colors: crimson, violet, deep orange, ash-white, midnight blue, sickly green, gold, and black.

These robes are heavy with wax seals, attached bones, stitched leather, and blood. The blood flows from the ritual masters, as their flesh is carved, turned into ritualistic art pieces. You can see the spiraling brands around their throats and geometric cuts beneath their eyes. Some of them stitched their lips only to be reopened during the ceremony.

Then they start chanting together.

"Flesh opens.
Father remembers.
Gate opens.
Blood remembers."

You see a crimson spark in the obsidian disk. As the chant continues, it turns into a light, cracking the disk and flowing outside. You hear someone laughing from the shadows.

Each ritual master is a **cult adept**. When the character approaches, one of them turns to the character and greets them calmly, "*Welcome. How lucky you are to experience something this unique.*" If the character or anyone else takes a hostile approach, numerous **cult initiates** will come out of hiding and attack them. There will be no end to the **cult initiates,** and they will slowly overwhelm the party.

Meanwhile, one of the **cult adepts** continues to speak, trying to persuade anyone to volunteer for the ritual. They claim that they can bring anyone back from death, and they do the ritual just to learn and study it; they don't desire to bring any specific person back. They ask the adventurers if they want their party member back, they ask Yngy if she wants her son back, and they ask the character if the character wants to revive the loved one.

At this point, every secret should be revealed, and a discussion should start between the party, Yngy, and the character. Yngy will claim that she doesn't want to be involved in an evil ritual, but the adventurers want to resurrect their fallen ally. The argument should become heated to a point of physical hostility between the character and the adventurers.

While all this is happening, Yngy will change her mind and approach the cultists as soon as she finds an opening, and she accepts the deal.

Read this section to your player.

The old eyes, burdened with the exhaustion of

decades, look back at you one last time. A tear slips sideways from her soft cheek and is drawn into the whirlpool of magical energies gathering as the cultists' bodies perish and rot. She tries to yell, but her voice is drowned out. She tries to tell you something, but the spell crackles and roars, awakening the forbidden.

The crimson spark erupts with a roar, and every stone pillar in the vicinity quakes and grinds. The last remaining ritual master turns to you and speaks in a bitter voice, every sound around him carrying the words to your ears: "*To take one, we must give another.*"

Gran reaches for the altar.

After reading this to your player, ask them what they will do. They have time to take one action. Gran Yngy is about to touch the altar; the character can rush in and touch the altar instead. They can give up and wait for the inevitable. The character can choose to attack the ritual master.

If Gran Yngy touches the altar, the character is drawn into the crimson spark and disappears. She gets her son back, who will commit suicide again within a year. The character is dragged to Hell.

If the character touches the altar, the crimson spark claims the character, but before it does, the character witnesses the resurrection of their loved one. The character is dragged to Hell.

If the ritual master dies, the accumulated magical energies explode, leaving a permanent dead magic zone and a vaporized temple ruins behind. Everyone within the vicinity is dragged to Hell.

GM Tip! Using the different parties involved in this mess, try to create the most annoying outcome for the character. Such as an adventurer shooting the character from behind, stopping the character from touching the altar before Gran. Make it annoying as Hell!

Read this section to your player after the character is dragged to Hell.

You sit at a table set for two. Fine silverware and ceramic plates rest before the seats. You look straight ahead, expecting company. There is no one. Only gray walls and blurred vision.

You look down at your plate. A fine turkey leg with onion gravy rests upon a bed of mashed potatoes. Your gaze drifts to the plate across the table. It is empty.

Strange, you think. Why do you feel the need to share your food with an empty seat?

And then, you no longer do.

Whoever it was, it seems they have already enjoyed their share. It is an empty seat before an empty plate, after all.

There is nothing in the room other than the table, seats, silverware, food, and a door. When the character approaches the door, they see it is already cracked open, and a dozen sets of eyes are watching from the other side.

Episode 3: A Deal Too Good To Pass

There are moments in history when fortune ceases to be a matter of chance and becomes a matter of timing. Kingdoms are built upon them, dynasties rise because a single visionary arrives at the right place at the right time and turns the tide. Entire generations spent their lives waiting for such an opening, only for it to pass unseen before their eyes. The moment has come, and fortune favors the bold.

In this episode, the character, a merchant both on the verge of starving to death and signing the agreement of a lifetime alongside their business partner, finds themselves caught in a web of intrigue and espionage. While pushing the deal toward completion, the character must investigate the intentions of the opposing party while slowly becoming entangled in the hidden motives of their own partners. What begins as a path toward unimaginable wealth soon turns

into a dangerous game of suspicion, manipulation, and betrayal.

The episode takes place in Cinderhall, a massive dwarven hall carved deep beneath the mountains, so vast that it resembles an underground city rather than a mere settlement. Endless mines, smelteries, workshops, and stone districts stretch through the cavernous depths, illuminated by the crimson glow of furnaces and molten metal. Cinderhall thrives on the extraction of Cinderheart, a rare red-glowing ore prized for its extraordinary heating properties. Even in its raw form, the metal radiates warmth like burning embers, making it invaluable for smithing, industry, and engineering. Merchants, miners, and powerful clans constantly compete for influence within the halls, where fortunes are forged alongside weapons and conspiracies alike.

The mining operation is hanging by a thread financially. Over the past several weeks, multiple expeditions sent into the deeper mining shafts have failed to return. Workers speak of strange noises rising from the abandoned tunnels. Until the threat is dealt with, workers refuse to descend into certain sections of the mines, and Mr. Cobbles refuses to move forward with the agreement. The threat within the mines comes from a **Cave Ogre** whose den lies beyond a section of rock that miners were never supposed to excavate. Recently, a rival mine company deliberately bribed a worker to dig toward the forbidden area, eventually breaking through into the creature's territory, instantly killed by the ogre. Workers report hearing monstrous growls coming from the deeper tunnels, and several miners and guards sent into the lower shafts were later found crushed.

For months, the character and Dagna Blackmantle have poured nearly everything they own into preparing the mines for large-scale extraction. Equipment was purchased on credit, workers were promised wages that have not yet fully arrived, and several local suppliers only continue providing goods because they personally know the character and Dagna, though their social credibility is rapidly depleting. In truth, the operation has almost no liquid funds remaining. A few more failed shipments or delayed payments could collapse the entire enterprise. In the meantime, landlords, lenders, tavern owners, and suppliers increasingly pressure the character for repayment, some growing openly hostile. Although the character stands on the edge of great wealth, they are simultaneously only days away from complete financial ruin.

Dagna has a secret child who is eighteen years old and has recently arrived in Cinderhall under a disguise. Their presence within the underground city is a major problem for Dagna, as she has kept this "second life" hidden from everyone for years. She is desperately trying to convince the child to leave the city before anyone discovers the truth. The child requires financial support, as they are currently on the run from bandits and have nowhere else to safely go.

The child must use the same pronouns as the character (for the sake of ease while writing, we will use they/them pronouns here). To secretly support them, Dagna has been selling small portions of Cinderheart without informing the character or recording the transactions properly. Behind closed doors, she attempts to persuade the child to leave without ever mentioning their name directly, referring to them only through pronouns matching the character's own. Because of this, the character may overhear fragmented whispers such as:

- *"They have to go."*
- *"I'm going to make them pay."*
- *"If they stay here, everything will collapse."*
- *"They cannot remain in this city."*
- *"You do not understand what they are risking."*
- *"If they are broke, they should get another job and leave me be. I can't have a freerider on my back."*

Upon hearing these conversations without proper context, the character may naturally assume that Dagna is speaking about them, further feeding the growing paranoia and suspicion throughout the episode.

Act 1: The Opportunity

The character is a native in Cinderhall, owning a small mining area. The character works alongside Dagna Blackmantle, a long-time business partner who owns half of the mining operation. Dagna is responsible for organizing transportation and trade logistics, while the character oversees the mines themselves, including the workers, security, and extraction efforts. Although the character already knows her well, this act should allow the player to slowly understand who Dagna truly is. She is practical, ambitious, sharp-minded, and exhausted from years of struggle beneath the mountain.

Recently, through Dagna's niece living in the distant city of Bronzewater, she established contact with a wealthy trader known as Mr. Cobbles. For years, the mines beneath the dwarven halls have produced Cinderheart, but never on a scale capable of changing the balance of trade throughout the region. Now, such an opportunity finally stands within reach, and the Act takes place during the final days before the signing of a monumental trade agreement.

Bronzewater currently suffers from a severe heating crisis. Charcoal grows scarce with each passing month, and a nearby druid circle fiercely opposes further logging in the surrounding forests. Woodcutters disappear, supply caravans are sabotaged, and fear spreads amongst the settlements relying on lumber for survival. Seeing an opportunity within the crisis, Mr. Cobbles intends to secure vast quantities of Cinderheart and establish a monopoly over the heating industry in Bronzewater before competitors can react.

The agreement would make everyone involved unimaginably wealthy. Throughout the act, the character meets the involved parties, negotiates terms, tours the mines, and slowly becomes familiar with the fragile network of interests surrounding the deal. Although the atmosphere is professional, tension quietly lingers beneath every conversation. Everyone involved understands that fortunes large enough to reshape cities rarely come without bloodshed.

In the first meeting with Mr. Cobbles, he should appear polite, professional, and calculating. His questions should sound reasonable. Throughout the meeting Dagna will answer swiftly to the questions but you as the GM should give time for the character to act and respond. Feel absolutely free to make Dagna sound suspicious or exclusionary. You'll find what Mr. Cobbles says and how Dagna further reacts below. Also, throughout the conversations, the character may try to understand the motives behind Dagna's behavior and words (Difficulty 15, increasing by 1 with each failure). On a failure, do not hesitate to misinform the character regarding Dagna's intentions and motives.

"You are not the only producers of Cinderheart in Cinderhall. There are larger operations with deeper tunnels and stronger labor forces. Why should I invest in your mines instead of theirs?"

Dagna answers before the character can fully respond. *"Because these mines are owned by fools drowning in their own size. They fight each other more than they dig. We are smaller, yes, but we can move faster. And unlike them, I'm... I mean we are willing to make difficult decisions without wasting months debating amongst ourselves."* The statement feels practical, but the way she says *"I'm"* feels strange, as though she speaks more for herself than for the partnership.

"You claim you can maintain steady production. Yet I hear rumors of labor shortages and unrest in the lower shafts. Why should I trust your stability?"

Dagna leans back in her chair before responding. *"Workers complain. That is what workers do. They complain when they are hungry, when they are tired, and when they are paid. But they stay; they always stay."* Then she briefly glances toward the character. *"And if certain matters become... inconvenient, I know how to resolve them, right?"* The wording should feel vague enough to sound threatening depending on how the character interprets it.

"If this agreement succeeds, Bronzewater may depend entirely upon your operation. What guarantees do I have that internal disagreements will not jeopardize my investment?"

For the first time, Dagna hesitates, and waits for a few seconds. *"The mines will continue operating regardless of circumstances."* Dagna calmly folds her hands together. *"As long as profit survives longer than people do."* Mr. Cobbles falls quiet for a moment and continues negotiating afterwards.

"What happens if one of you decides they no longer wish to share ownership once we agreed? I find businesses with more than one owner harder to agree with."

Dagna gives a small laugh before the character can answer. *"Then I suppose we would discover how valuable loyalty truly is. Because I ain't leaving."* She says it jokingly, yet Mr. Cobbles raises an eyebrow, letting everyone know that he found the joke somehow unnecessary.

"Mining operations of this scale tend to attract desperate folk, rivals, criminals, old friends and foes... Tell me honestly, should I be worried about any of these things with your own enterprise?"

Dagna answers this one quietly. *"Worry is healthy in business, Mr. Cobbles. Those who stop worrying are usually the first to disappear. I find our muscles good enough."* Then she changes the subject immediately afterward, refusing to elaborate further.

Let the character ask any questions or make further remarks about the negotiation. However, otherwise the negotiations end here.

Shortly before the first negotiation is finalized, Mr. Cobbles raises concerns regarding the safety of the mines. Recent expeditions into the deeper tunnels have failed to return, workers refuse to descend into certain shafts, and monstrous noises echo through abandoned sections of the excavation routes. Mr. Cobbles understands that such problems may occur in mining operations, but he refuses to send his caravans unless the threat is dealt with first. The agreement cannot move forward while the mines remain unstable.

Act 2: Beneath The Mountain

The character must now solve the problem in the mining area before the entire deal collapses. They may attempt to gather capable adventurers, hire mercenaries, bribe guards, or commission desperate laborers willing to descend into the tunnels alongside them. However, the mining operation is already on the verge of financial collapse, and the character's choices during this act will have consequences for their personal life later in Act 3. Here are some of their choices and their possible outcomes.

Hiring Adventurers

The character may attempt to recruit capable adventurers from nearby taverns and guildhouses to solve the problem in the mines (Difficulty 10).

On a success, the threat is resolved in a professional manner; however, the cost is enormous. The operation sinks deeper into debt, and the character will encounter all of the listed debt collection encounters in Act 3. Dagna becomes visibly irritated by the expense and does not hesitate to tell the character so.

On a failure, the hired group dies or flees, and the character must find a new way to solve the problem. If so, the character will encounter all of the listed debt collection encounters in Act 3.

Bribing Guards

The character may commission guards from Cinderhall to solve the problem in the mines (Difficulty 13).

On a success, the threat is resolved, but some of the guards die during the conflict. However, the operation loses nearly all remaining liquid funds, and the character will encounter two of the listed debt collection encounters in Act 3.

On a failure, the hired group dies or flees, and the character must find a new way to solve the problem. If so, the character will encounter all of the listed debt collection encounters in Act 3.

Descending Into the Mines

The character may choose to solve the problem in the mines themselves with three trusted miners by their side. If the character chooses this route, Dagna becomes very supportive of the decision, almost overly excited for the character to descend into the mines. She believes this is the cheapest option available and good for business. However, this reaction may appear suspicious to the character.

If the character personally descends into the mines, they will encounter one of the listed debt collection encounters in Act 3.

Inside the mines, allow the character to successfully clear the tunnels; they should not die here, although some workers may die during the expedition. The character can locate evidence of sabotage (Difficulty 12). A wall in the tunnel that should never have been excavated has been dug through deeply enough to break into a **Cave Ogre**'s den.

If the sabotage is discovered, suspicion naturally begins shifting toward rival mines, or even toward Dagna herself after the character overhears her speaking about her child. In truth, the sabotage is the doing of a rival mine who bribed a worker to dig the spot. The worker has died in a mining accident, so there is no way to confirm who commissioned the sabotage.

Act 3: Debts To Be Paid

The conflict within the mines is resolved, and the character returns home. This act is divided into two parts. Debt encounters are designed to reflect how financially unstable the character has become and how desperately they need the agreement with Mr. Cobbles to succeed. Dagna encounters are designed to make the character increasingly suspicious of their business partner.

Debt encounters begin while the character is at home and continue throughout their journey toward the office. Dagna encounters begin just outside the office and continue while the character remains there. The choices the character made during the previous act affect how many Debt encounters they will face.

Debt (Must Encounter): Rent Overdue

The character is not able to pay their rent for months, and the landlord's patience has been depleted. The character is in their home, sipping tea and getting ready to go to the office they share with Dagna.

When the character arrives home after a long workday, read this section to your player.
Somehow, the ogre problem of the mines is resolved. The warmth of the tea slowly spreads through your body as you sit within the quiet of your home. Your muscles ache from the exhaustion of the mines, either from fighting or working, and the smell of dust, sweat, and damp stone still clings to your clothes despite your efforts to wash. The troubles of the mine finally feel distant for the first time in days. For a brief moment, you allow yourself to breathe and loosen your shoulders as the steam rises gently from the cup in your hands. Then, suddenly, three harsh knocks slam against the door; they are neither polite nor hesitant. A fist pounds against the wood with the confidence of someone who expects the door to open immediately. Another impatient knock follows before you can even rise from your chair. Whoever waits outside does not intend to leave quietly.

The character may carefully approach the door and attempt to look outside without being noticed (Difficulty 15). On a success, they spot their landlord standing before the entrance alongside three broad-shouldered thugs wearing mining jackets (**Bladed Guards**) with the sleeves torn off. On a failure, one of the men notices movement behind the window or beneath the door. One of them suddenly slams a fist against the wood again and shouts, *"We know you're in there!"* making it impossible for the character to continue hiding unnoticed.

If the character opens the door and confronts the landlord, the landlord immediately begins demanding overdue payments in an aggressive tone. He complains that promises do not pay debts and claims he has already waited longer

than anyone else would have. The three men behind him mostly remain silent, standing close enough to feel threatening without immediately escalating into violence.

The character may attempt to calm the situation, negotiate for more time, threaten the landlord back, offer partial payment, or promise that the agreement with Mr. Cobbles will soon solve everything. If the character successfully persuades the landlord (Difficulty 13), the landlord reluctantly grants a few more days, though he warns that next time he will not come peacefully. If the character fails or insults the landlord in any way, combat initiates. The character cannot pay with gold; however, they can offer valuables from their house, the landlord becomes calmer and leaves after making several passive-aggressive remarks regarding trust and debt.

GM Tip! This scene is meant to reinforce the character's growing desperation and financial instability. Even if the confrontation does not turn violent, the character should feel cornered and pressured from all sides.

Debt: The Silent Watcher

While the character is walking toward their office, they may notice a cloaked figure **(Sellsword)** was following them throughout Cinderhall (Difficulty 15). A hooded dwarf stands next to a streetlamp, pretending to read shipment records near the mining area. If the character confronts them or attempts to corner the dwarf, he calmly explains that he works for Lady Heliur, a wealthy moneylender who financed part of the mining operation's recent expenses.

The cloaked dwarf speaks without anger. *"We are not here to hurt you. Lady Heliur simply dislikes uncertainty. Large debts make people disappear sometimes. She wished to ensure you were still in the city."* The dwarf insists that Lady Heliur expects repayment soon and politely reminds the character that patience has limits. Even after the confrontation ends, the character occasionally notices similar figures observing them from balconies, taverns, and crowded market paths. They are not hostile, but if the character acts aggressively toward them, they will not hesitate to fight. If the character is unable to locate the dwarf, they later find a note inside their bag reading, *"Large debts make people disappear."*

Debt: Public Humiliation

While the character walks through one of Cinderhall's crowded market corridors, where their office is also located, a supplier loudly confronts them before nearby workers and merchants. The supplier accuses the character of avoiding payments and claims they are tired of hearing promises about future profits. The argument quickly attracts attention from bystanders and laborers familiar with the mining operation. The supplier is not truly interested in repayment, but rather in publicly humiliating the character. Therefore, feel free to include insults and slurs if your table is comfortable with it.

The character may attempt to calm the supplier, lie about incoming payments, intimidate them into silence, or publicly defend themselves. If the character successfully persuades the supplier (Difficulty 15), the confrontation ends with bitter warnings and muttering from the crowd. On a failure, the supplier loudly declares that the mining operation is collapsing financially, spreading rumors amongst nearby workers and merchants. If the character threatens violence, nearby guards intervene and the situation becomes even more publicly humiliating.

GM Tip! This encounter is meant to reinforce the feeling that the character's financial troubles are no longer private. Their debts are beginning to follow them openly throughout the city. Make this encounter as distressing as possible. Let the character enter the office with heavy thoughts weighing on their mind.

Dagna: Rumors

As the character approaches the office, they overhear two workers speaking quietly near a stack of mining crates (Difficulty 12). One of them notices the character too late and awkwardly lowers his voice, though not before the character catches part of the conversation. "I'm telling you, Blackmantle found herself

another partner already. Folk like us don't climb out of poverty twice with the same people." The other worker mutters something about shipments and contracts before noticing the character approaching and immediately pretending to focus on work. The character can understand that they were talking about them if they didn't hear what they said (Difficulty 11)

If the character confronts the workers, the first one quickly becomes nervous and defensive. He insists he only heard rumors from taverns and loading crews and admits that he does not actually know who Dagna has supposedly been meeting with. The character may determine that the worker is telling the truth on a successful roll (Difficulty 13). He mentions seeing unfamiliar merchants around the office recently and claims that everyone knows rich folk make backup plans. The worker genuinely does not know that the rumors are referring to Mr. Cobbles and assumes Dagna is secretly preparing a separate business arrangement behind the character's back.

Dagna: Behind Closed Doors

As the character enters the office, they notice that Dagna's door is shut. Muffled voices leak through the wooden door (Difficulty 10). Dagna is speaking in a harsh whisper filled with restrained fury, pacing heavily enough for the floorboards to creak beneath her boots. Replace the pronouns below to match the character's.

If the character hears Dagna, read this section to your player.
"No, no, no... they cannot stay here." A loud slam follows, as though something was struck against the desk. As you try to hear the words coming from Dagna's mouth, you hear the voice of a glass broken. *"They already have half of what's mine! What more do they want from me?"* Silence reigns for a moment before Dagna speaks again, quieter this time, though trembling with anger and panic. *"I'm gonna kill them. That's what'll happen eventually."*

If the character enters suddenly, Dagna immediately falls silent and pretends everything is ordinary, though she fails terribly to do so. She demands to know how long the character was standing outside the door. She refuses to explain the conversation and quickly changes the subject back toward work and the agreement. Nothing helps Dagna admit the truth about her child to the character.

GM Tip! This encounter is meant to sow the first true seeds of betrayal and paranoia within the character's mind. The player should naturally begin suspecting that Dagna is speaking about them, especially due to the matching pronouns and the ongoing tension surrounding the agreement. Do not clarify the misunderstanding by any means. Let suspicion slowly poison the partnership.

After a brief moment, Dagna steps out and goes out of office with fast steps. The character can confront Dagna here, if they haven't entered the room.

Dagna: Behind Closed Doors

While Dagna is away from the office, the character may choose to investigate her room and work desk. Ledgers, shipment records, and accounting documents are scattered across the table in a disorganized state, as though they were searched through in haste. At first glance, everything appears ordinary, but the character may notice inconsistencies between shipment manifests and extraction reports (Difficulty 14).

On a success, the character realizes that small portions of Cinderheart have recently gone missing from storage without official records or payments attached to them. The quantities are not large enough to seriously damage the business on their own, and the missing ore certainly does not amount to a fortune. However, considering the already desperate financial situation, the discovery still feels unsettling. Several balances fail to match, and some shipment pages appear partially rewritten or altered. The character may begin wondering how much else has gone unnoticed until now.

GM Tip! After the character discovers the inconsistencies in the ledgers, ask them to roll a Duality Die (Difficulty 17). This roll is not about determining whether Dagna stole the ore, but

about how deeply the discovery affects the character psychologically. On a failure, the question begins eating away at the character's mind; if Dagna was willing to secretly take even small portions of ore, what else might she have hidden over the years? What other agreements, lies, or betrayals remain unseen beneath the surface? Did Dagna find another business partner that is not starving to death? Is Dagna trying to eliminate the character and sign the agreement with Mr. Cobbles all by herself?

Let paranoia slowly settle into the character's thoughts and influence how they interpret future interactions with Dagna.
On a success with Fear, the character suppresses the paranoia, but only barely. Instead of quiet suspicion, they feel an overwhelming urge to immediately confront Dagna about the missing ore and the inconsistencies in the records.

Act 4: Confrontation

The character stands at the edge of a terrible decision. The paranoia, resentment, and fear cultivated throughout the episode may finally push them toward action. Dagna Blackmantle has disappeared before the final meeting with Mr. Cobbles, and no one seems to know where she went. Some claim she left during the night, while some others insist they saw her arguing with someone near the lower districts of Cinderhall.

The character must now find Dagna, whether their intention is to confront her, kill her, force her to explain herself, or simply drag her to the final meeting with Mr. Cobbles. Throughout the search, the character hears rumors regarding an unfamiliar person moving through the city, a cloaked young traveler seen near the main gates during the previous night.

Eventually, the character discovers Dagna lying beside one of the mud-covered roads of Cinderhall. The crimson glow of nearby ores reflects dimly against the wet stone around her body. She has been stabbed repeatedly and left bleeding amongst the industrial filth flowing beneath the city. She has bled to death. Near the scene, signs of a desperate struggle are visible alongside smaller footprints leading away into the darkness.

Inside Dagna's robe, the character can locate two letters (Difficulty 12). The first letter is addressed directly to the character. The handwriting is rushed but the character easily recognizes that it belongs to Dagna. She explains that she secretly paid the next month of the character's rent so they would not need to worry about losing their home while the agreement was being finalized. The letter avoids emotional honesty almost entirely, yet its intention is unmistakably caring.

The second letter is older and partially crumpled, written by Dagna's child. The letter desperately asks for financial help and explains that they are being hunted by sellswords after falling into debt and conflict while fleeing bandits outside Cinderhall. Several lines mention fear, exhaustion, and nowhere left to run.

At that moment, the horrifying truth begins settling into the character's mind; despite every suspicion and every missing shipment, Dagna may never have intended betrayal at all. Yet by the time the truth reveals itself, distrust has already consumed everything between them.

After the character finds Dagna, read this section to your player.
Dagna's death destroyed the agreement entirely. When you finally met Mr. Cobbles again, the trader no longer spoke with the warmth of opportunity in his voice. The murder within your own enterprise changed everything. Mr. Cobbles believed the mines were now unstable, cursed by debt, sabotage, disappearances, and bloodshed. Within days, Mr. Cobbles reached an agreement with one of the rival mining groups of Cinderhall. Without Dagna, everything began to rot away around you. Workers abandoned the mines for safer employers, suppliers refused further cooperation, debt collectors stopped speaking politely, and the halls that once felt familiar now felt colder with each passing day. Rumors surrounding Dagna's death spread throughout the underground city, and your name slowly became attached to them. Some believed you killed her, while others simply believed ruin followed you wherever you went. Soon enough, the consequences arrived. One night, while you were walking through the

lower districts of Cinderhall, you noticed footsteps behind you. Sellswords, they were. Whether they had been sent by Lady Heliur, a rival mine, an old creditor, or one of the countless enemies you made within Cinderhall no longer mattered. You ran for dear life. Your breath felt heavy in your chest while distant shouts and footsteps grew closer behind you. You ran through the alleyways until finally you reached a dead end, and there, waiting at the end of the narrow passage, stood a black door. With nowhere else to go, you rushed toward the door and threw yourself inside.

The world disappeared.
Only primordial blackness.

Episode 4: Why not?

There is no reason behind everything. Logic will not take you everywhere, and you won't be able to question this. There are things. These things happen. Pondering beyond this is stupid because things will continue happening. Think how funny your analysis is for someone who hasn't happened yet.

In this episode, the character is already in Hell. The character thinks that they are at the exit, and if they can overcome the challenge ahead, they will escape Hell.

This episode is a fast-paced combat dungeon, which the character challenges again and again with every defeat. There are no stories, no logic, and no diplomacy in this episode.

Act 1: Go!

The character believes that they are at the end of Hell, which is a long, corridor-shaped dungeon. They think that by getting to the end of the dungeon, they can escape. This is just another Hell torment.

The corridor starts from a large cylindrical room with sandstone walls. It is currently empty and dark. Only the light coming from the corridor can be seen. Whenever the character dies, they return to this room and are considered to have completed a long rest. Also, with each return, the character can add something to the room or improve it. For example, they can add light and then make it brighter; they can add a stool, change it to a table, and upgrade it to a bar table with shelves.

Whenever the character dies and gets back to the room, the entire dungeon resets.

There are 6 sections of the corridor, each 100 feet wide and 300 feet long. At the end of each corridor, there is a force barrier barring entry; the character must take the appropriate action described at the end of each corridor to disable the force barrier.

If a character keeps failing to complete a corridor section, they gain a level.

Whenever the character steps into the corridor, read this to your player. Read it every time.

You step into the corridor. Lava flows along the sides, eager for your arrival; bursts of fire erupt in welcome; lightning rips through the air, and a red-skinned demon twice your size appears before you. The headless brute, an amalgamation of bulging muscle, opens its arms in celebration.

"WELCOME TO THE ARENA!"

After greeting the character, the demon disappears, and the character gains the spotlight.

Section 1

Whenever the character gains the spotlight, 1d2 pervert imps appear at random places within the corridor. They are hostile to the character.

PERVERT IMP

Tier 1 Minion
A small naked creature with its genitals out. It has useless wings, a short pig tail, deer horns, and red scaly skin.
Motives & Tactics: Hump

Difficulty: 10 | **Threshold:** None | **HP:** 1 | **Stress:** 1
ATK: -4 | **Fist:** Melee | 1 phy

Experience: -

FEATURES

Minion (4) - ***Passive:*** The Imp is defeated when they take any damage. For every 4 damage a PC deals to the Imp, defeat an additional Minion within range the attack would succeed against.

Hump - ***Action:*** The Imp clings to the target and starts humping the target. Whenever the target gains the spotlight, **gain a Fear** for each imp currently clinging to the target.

When the character reaches the end of the corridor, the imps run away and disappear. A cat is lying on a pedestal. The following words are engraved on the pedestal, just under the cat: “Do Not Pet The Fluff.”

If the character pets the cat, the cat dies, and the dungeon collapses, killing the character. If the character continues without petting the cat, the force barrier disappears. After several successful attempts, the cat starts to walk towards the character, trying to appear cute, begging the character to pet them.

Section 2

There is a carp demon in the corridor. Whenever a carp demon dies, 1d2 carp demons appear at random places within the corridor. They are hostile to the character.

CARP DEMON

Tier 1 Standard
A muscular humanoid with a fish head, wielding an anchor.
Motives & Tactics: Run to a random direction

Difficulty: 12 | **Threshold:** 4/8 | **HP:** 2 | **Stress:** 2
ATK: +1 | **Anchor:** Melee | 1d10+2 phy

Experience: Swim +2

FEATURES

Heavy Attack - ***Action:*** **Mark a Stress** to make a standard attack. If the target takes damage, they are also pushed back to Close range by the impact.

Roe - ***Passive:*** When the Carp Demon dies, roll a d6. On a 6, the demon explodes in a burst of roe. Any Carp Demons witnessing this are permanently *Maddened*. While *Maddened*, the Carp Demon runs to random directions and attacks the closest creature.

When the character reaches the end of the corridor, all carp demons explode in a burst of roe at the same time. If there are more than 10 carp demons, the character is deafened by the shock of the explosion.

There is a pedestal with a glass bottle on top. The following words are engraved on the pedestal, just under the bottle: “Vigor, Sanity, Speed. Speak two and take one.” After the character speaks two of these three words, the potion corresponding to the unspoken word fills the bottle. After the character takes the bottle, the force field disappears.

- Vigor Potion: The character clears all HP.
- Sanity Potion: The character clears all stress.
- Speed Potion: Whenever the GM spends Fear, they must spend twice the normal amount.

Section 3

Whenever the character gains the spotlight, a hexer demon appears at random places within the corridor. They are hostile to the character.

HEXER DEMON

Tier 1 Support
A voodoo-doll wielding blood red demon, using hexes to lead enemies towards the damnation.
Motives & Tactics: Curse, hex

Difficulty: 13 | **Threshold:** 5/9| **HP:** 2 | **Stress:** 2
ATK: +2 | **Voodoo Doll:** Far | 1d6+2 mag

Experience: Curses +2

FEATURES

Hex - ***Action:*** Choose a target within Far range, and temporarily *Hex* them. While the target is *Hexed*, you can **mark a Stress** when that target

marks an Armor Slot to ignore the marked Armor Slot.

Forceful Polymorph - ***Reaction:*** When a PC takes an action, **spend a Fear** and the GM yells a word. If the PC fails to yell a synonym, acronym, or antonym of the word within 10 seconds, the character is transformed into a random tiny animal before the action is concluded. The character can't use reactions in this form. The character reverts to its original form when it gains the spotlight.

When the character reaches the end of the corridor, a conductor demon appears before them. The demon is hostile to the character.

CONDUCTOR DEMON

Tier 1 Leader
An amalgamation of mouths, eyes, arms, and legs.
Motives & Tactics: Run, hide, command

Difficulty: 15 | **Threshold:** 6/10| **HP:** 6 | **Stress:** 4
ATK: +4 | **Slap:** Melee | 1d4+1 phy

Experience: Annoy +3, Lie +2

FEATURES

Hype Up Demons - ***Action:*** **Spend 2 Fear** to spotlight the Conductor Demon and up to 1d4 allies within Far range.

Better Allies - ***Passive:*** The Conductor Demon's allies within Far range can spend a character's hope instead of spending a Fear while using a feature.

Momentum - ***Reaction:*** When the Conductor Demon makes a successful attack against a PC, you gain a Fear.

When the Conductor Demon dies, all Hexer Demons die with it. Then, the force barrier disappears.

Section 4

When the character gains the spotlight for the first time in this section, activate Countdown (6). Whenever the character gains the spotlight, it ticks down. When it triggers, the character explodes into numerous tiny objects, such as pebbles, coins, and erasers, and dies. Whenever the character kills an adversary, reset the countdown.

There is a Sun Disk Minotaur in the corridor. It is not hostile to the character until the character tries to get past it.

SUN DISK MINOTAUR

Tier 1 Bruiser
A large minotaur with a gilded disk suspended between the horns, wielding a khopesh.
Motives & Tactics: Analyze, try, repeat

Difficulty: 14 | **Threshold:** 8/13 | **HP:** 2 | **Stress:** 5
ATK: +1 | **Khopesh:** Melee | 2d6 phy

Experience: Arcane +3, Time studies +4

FEATURES

Paradox - ***Action:*** **Mark a Stress** to revert time to the end of your previous spotlight. When the Sun Disk Minotaur reverts time, a Paradox Pixie appears in a random place within the Far range.

Parry - ***Reaction:*** When the Sun Disk Minotaur is attacked, roll 2d6. If any of the attacker's damage dice rolled the same value as the minotaur's dice, the matching results are discarded from the attacker's damage dice.

Never Happened - ***Passive:*** When the Sun Disk Minotaur dies, it reappears from a paradox pixie, if there are any Paradox Pixies within Far range. The pixie disappears, and the minotaur appears in its place, with all conditions, afflictions, curses, and similar negative effects removed, and HP and stress fully cleared.

PARADOX PIXIE

Tier 1 Minion
A small ball of 4th-dimensional light.
Motives & Tactics: Move around

Difficulty: 10 | **Threshold:** None | **HP:** 1 | **Stress:** 1
ATK: -4 | **Age:** Melee | 1 mag

Experience: -

FEATURES

Minion (1) - ***Passive:*** The Paradox Pixie is defeated when they take any damage. For every 1 damage a PC deals to the Paradox Pixie, defeat an additional Minion within range the attack would succeed against.

Time Chaos - ***Passive:*** When the Paradox Pixie dies, all active countdowns tick up or down once. Roll a d2 for each countdown to decide.

When the Sun Disk Minotaur dies, and there are no pixies to bring it back, the character feels the urge to say a one-liner about this encounter.

There is a mirror at the end of the corridor. While looking at it, the character sees the clothes they imagine in their reflection. If the character wishes, they can change clothes with their reflection, acquiring the imagined clothes. Choose a random color on each run, requiring the character to wear that color to pass the force barrier.

Section 5

When the character gains the spotlight for the first time in this section, three flying imps holding scoreboards appear alongside a **Spectacle Demon**. The imps remain out of reach as they are behind the barrier, while the Spectacle Demon prepares to attack. When the imps first appear, they shout, *"Go wild, go stylish, go fun!"*

Whenever a character makes an attack against the demon, the three imps each give a score from 1 to 5. The first imp scores the recklessness of the attack, the second imp scores its stylishness, and the third imp scores the humor of the one-liner delivered alongside the attack. Provided that the attack hits the demon, the total score given by the imps determines the damage dealt by the attack.

SPECTACLE DEMON

Tier 1 Solo

A fiend draped in velvet and gold, with a porcelain grin stretched across its face.

Motives & Tactics: Humiliate, entertain, provoke

Difficulty: 14 | **Threshold:** 8/11 | **HP:** 8 | **Stress:** 8
ATK: +2 | **Curtain Call:** Melee | 1d6 mag

Experience: Performer +3

FEATURES

Curtain Call - ***Action:*** **Spend 1 Fear** to lash out with clawed hands and sweeping ribbons of infernal silk. If the Spectacle Demon makes a successful attack against a PC, the PC is unable to move until the Spectacle Demon regains the spotlight.

Infernal Tomatoes - ***Passive:*** Mark a Stress to command the imps to throw flaming rotten fruit at a creature within Far range that received fewer than 7 points for their last attack. The creature must make an Agility Roll. On a failure, the creature takes 2d8 + 3 magical damage.

The Fear of the Spotlight - ***Reaction:*** When a PC that was hit by the Curtain Call action gains spotlight, you gain Fear.

When the Spectacle Demon dies, all three imps raise scoreboards marked with a perfect 10. Then, the imps disappear.

At the end of the corridor, there is a golden cup filled with a gilded metallic liquid. It smells of lamb liver and coal. If you drink it, the force barrier disappears, and you have the following benefits in Section 6.

- You can take domain cards from your vault without marking Stress.
- You clear 1 HP and 1 Stress when you gain the spotlight.

Section 6

When the character gains the spotlight for the first time in this section, the Gate Keeper appears before the giant metallic door on the other side of the corridor. The circular dark door is decorated in infernal runes, still glowing with hellfire.

Whenever the character arrives before the Gate Keeper, the keeper tells the character how boring it is to do the same thing over and over

again. Even after the character's first arrival, the keeper comments, *"Aren't you bored of trying?"*

GATE KEEPER

Tier 2 Solo
A lean demon with red skin and goat horns, wielding a pitchfork. It has leathery wings and a long, pointy tail.
Motives & Tactics:

Difficulty: 16 | **Threshold:** 14/26 | **HP:** 9 | **Stress:** 7
ATK: +5 | **Pitchfork:** Very Close | 3d12+3

Experience: Hell Lore +2

FEATURES

Clash of Egos - ***Action:*** **Spend 1 Fear** to tell a target within Close range some evil thing that the Gate Keeper has done. The target must respond and match the vileness by making a Presence Roll. On a failure, the Gate Keeper immediately moves towards the target and makes a standard attack, dealing direct damage on a success.

Hellfireball - ***Action:*** **Spend X Fear** and shoot a fireball made of Hellfire to a point within Far range. Everything within Close range of that point takes Xd10 mag damage.

Fuck Around - ***Action:*** **Spend 1 Fear** and target a PC. The character must switch the amount of marked HP and Stress with each other.

You Are Not Worthy - ***Reaction:*** When a creature within Very Close range fails an attack against the Gate Keeper, the demon mocks their weakness mercilessly and the creature **marks 1 Stress.** If the attack is failed with Fear, the creature **marks 2 Stress** instead.

After the Gate Keeper is defeated, the character can approach the metal door at the end of the corridor. When the character touches the door, they realize that it is not a door but just plates of metal fastened to the wall. Then, the Gate Keeper's body starts to boil, and eventually, it explodes, killing the character.

When the character returns to the starting room, a prismatic crystalline door appears in the room. When the character opens the door, the demon who greets the character at the start of each run appears behind the character and pushes the character through the door.

Moments Before Madness

The characters are dead and now reside in Hell. As is customary, all who descend into Hell are subjected to torture. Some burn within ever-flaming fires, while others freeze inside permafrost graves. After a thousand years of torment, the residents of Hell are released and allowed to roam freely until demons come to take them to their next punishment.

Between these cycles of torture, the residents of Hell may do whatever lies within their power. However, the moment when the next session of torment begins remains unknown to them.

As with all damned souls, the characters in this adventure are subjected to this cycle. Yet their suffering follows a far more unorthodox path.

The Poet

The Poet was once a creature of pride in life believing his enchanting words are superior to all else. The powers of Hell claimed his soul, and he was condemned to eternal torment, as are all who descend into its depths. However, after thousands of years of begging and subservience, the nature of the Poet's punishment changed. He was given charge over the torment of certain newcomers, free to shape their suffering in his own twisted ways.

The Poet possesses a leather-bound notebook with endless pages. Whatever he writes about the lost souls of the afterlife becomes reality. The forces of Hell inform him which souls he is to torment next, and he begins writing their tragic and fated events into his notebook.

Thus, the characters' initial torment comes in the form of the challenges the Poet writes for them. At first, they do not realize this, but the paths they take and the events they experience

have already been written. In some encounters, their actions may not yield the desired results, for nothing can occur beyond what the Poet has already set in motion while his will still holds power.

The Poet's torment takes place within the minds of the characters. Until they find a way to break free, they do not truly experience Hell itself, only a reflection of it shaped by his words.

He designs these trials to test the characters morally. They may encounter an innocent child burning in boiling blood, or a bound phoenix soul weeping in despair. The Poet watches closely, judging whether they will offer aid or turn away.

If he deems them worthy, if he senses even a fragment of goodness within them, he binds their souls together forever. On the final page of his notebook, he writes: "They will be the first to break the mark of Hell and escape it when the Rise of the Sinlord begins."

He does this with a singular hope. He believes that if someone can escape Hell, and if he aids those who still carry goodness within them, the Heavens may yet reward him by lifting his soul from damnation. Whether this hope is foolish or true will ultimately be determined by the choices the characters make.

The Mark of Hell

All creatures who descend into Hell, or are born within it, bear a mark known as the Mark of Hell. Some marks are visible, while others remain unseen, but none are without them. Through this mark, the forces of Hell always know when it is time for a creature's torment, as well as the whereabouts of any soul attempting to escape.

The Mark of Hell cannot be broken, altered, or weakened by any means. However, its appearance and visibility may be determined by the player, at the GM's discretion.

The Deadly Sins

Before starting the adventure and creating the characters, please ask your players what their characters' most prominent deadly sin is. The sin their characters are most inclined toward will have meaning throughout the adventure and may alter certain encounters to better reflect their personalities and inner flaws. Of course, a character's prominent sin may change over the course of the story.

Players can also use their chosen sin for roleplaying purposes, as the seven deadly sins provide an excellent foundation for creating flawed characters with narrative depth. A wrathful character may become angry quickly, while a greedy one may feel more inclined toward theft, and so on.

The Coin of Fate

With *Demonheart*, we are introducing the Coin of Fate, which allows players to ease the narrative consequences of failure on a personal level. At the start of a session, place the coin in a neutral position on the table.

The use of the Coin of Fate is granted to a player when they act in accordance with their prominent deadly sin. When the GM grants this right, the player takes the coin and keeps it beside them.

When a player fails an action roll, the player holding the coin may challenge fate. They declare a side of the coin (Fortune or Doom) and toss it.

If the declared side lands face up, that character is not affected by the narrative consequences of the failure. For example, if the party falls from a great height, the character who succeeds on the coin toss may avoid the fall entirely or take no damage. The player and GM should work together to determine the exact outcome.

If the opposite side lands face up, the party gains 1 Mark of Fate. When the party reaches a total of 10 Marks of Fate, all marks are erased, and the

forces of Fate prepare a challenging encounter for the party.

After the coin is tossed, it is returned to its neutral place on the table. If another player acts in accordance with their chosen sin while a different player currently holds the coin, the Coin of Fate changes hands, and the new player becomes its holder. You may use a regular coin until you receive the official Coin of Fate.

Descent into Hell

After playing or narratively describing the characters' death scenes, you can continue with this section.

Read this section to your players.

As you close your eyes for the last time, you feel a quiet resentment, perhaps toward yourself, toward the ambitions that led to your demise, or toward the world that treated you so harshly. You did not have to die. No... Alas, you are drawing the final breaths you will ever take, speaking the last words that leave your mouth, and witnessing the final fragile moments that remain. Then... that is it. There is nothing but death and darkness from now on. You died...

Your loved ones, your unfinished business, your goals... You left them astray. As your soul begins its final journey toward its resting place, you feel a strange sensation. A feeling... A sense of struggle, of immense pain and suffering, of biting coldness. Something strangles you. You feel the cold weight of a chain upon your soul, coiling, tightening, refusing to let go. A chain that forever marks your essence with a bitter, dismal, suffocating presence.

You open your eyes before a black door standing in the middle of an endless void. There is nothing else to do but open it. Your feet move backward, trembling, yet the chains constricting you pull you forward. Your new life welcomes you.

The characters are within the mindscape of the Poet. He knows what happened, what is happening, and what will happen inside his mindscape. In truth, both the characters and the Poet reside within the Poet's study room. He sits upon a chair of bone before a table of bones, writing poems and deciding the fate of the characters with every word he inscribes upon the humanoid leather sheets laid before him. The characters sit upon smaller chairs before the table, unconscious and chained.

The following chapter takes place as a series of visions experienced by the characters. They do not know, and should not know, that their torment is written and directed by the Poet, nor that they remain chained and unconscious within his study beside him.

Chapter 1: Memoirs of the False Artist

Deep was my anguish for those words
They froze my blood and chained my soul
The master had spoken the truth, not any lies

The Devil gives and evil takes
The things in life that man forsakes
A throne in Hell, a price or a sacrifice?
- Candlemass, Under the Oak

This chapter contains seven episodes. Each episode is designed to reflect one of the seven deadly sins. Through these episodes, the characters will embrace their sins and endure tortures designed specifically for them.

This chapter takes place entirely within the mindscape of the Poet, the NPC responsible for the characters' torment. Everything the characters experience is part of a controlled vision shaped by him. The Poet already knows what has happened, what is happening, and what will happen within his mindscape. These visions are not random dreams or illusions, but deliberate acts of torment and storytelling created by the Poet himself.

In reality, the characters are unconscious and physically located within the Poet's study room. Each character is chained to a small chair positioned before the Poet's desk. The Poet sits upon a throne-like chair made of bone, writing upon humanoid leather sheets stretched across his table. Every word he inscribes directly shapes the visions the characters experience.

The characters must never become aware of this truth during the chapter. They should believe the visions are real experiences happening directly to them. The existence of the study room, the chains, and the Poet's role as the author of their suffering should remain hidden unless the GM intentionally decides to reveal it later in the campaign.

The characters will encounter black doors at the end of each episode, which serve as transitions deeper into the Poet's constructed visions. At the beginning of the chapter, the characters are surrounded and constricted by seven chains. As they delve further into the mindscape, the chains disappear one by one. Each chain represents one of the deadly sins, and whenever the characters undergo the torment associated with a specific sin, the related chain vanishes. The chains pulling the characters forward also symbolize the Poet's control over them and their inability to resist the tortures prepared for them.

GM Tip! If you would like to play with the characters' minds, you can make them hear the Poet's voice as though a writer were whispering and describing the characters' actions while composing a poem. Better yet, the characters may discover manuscripts or writings upon walls narrating their actions precisely as they unfold. You can gradually push the characters toward the terrifying realization that they may possess no free will within this realm.

Episode 1: Chains of Guilt

After the characters descend into Hell and regain their senses, they remember passing through a door, its size and shape determined by the GM and influenced by the ending of Chapter 0. They find themselves standing upon a stone platform measuring 10 feet on each side. The platform is surrounded by a lake of lava and bursting flames. On the southern side of the platform lies a narrow path made of darkened cobblestones approximately 4 inches wide and 600 feet long. The path leads toward a massive black door.

The black door is made of solid metal. It stands 20 feet tall and 10 feet wide. Its surface is engraved with infernal figures and the seven sigils of the deadly sins. Apart from the platform, the path, and the door, there is nothing but the lake of lava and eternal silence.

Seven spectral chains protrude from the ground around each character, binding them from different directions. The characters are still free to walk. However, if they attempt to fly, the chains prevent them from doing so. These chains are covered in different infernal runes, vile prayers praising the hellish lord of the deadly sin toward which the character is most inclined. The characters may deduce that the runes upon the chains resemble the sigils engraved upon the door once they come close enough to properly discern them (Difficulty 13).

The characters' objective is to reach the door by walking along the narrow path. However, while they move forward, the chains attempt to pull them into the lava lake.

Moving along the path without falling into the lake requires good reflexes (Difficulty 17), though the characters may instead choose to listen to the voice of the Poet to safely reach the door. The following events occur based on each character's associated deadly sin.

If a character fails the roll to move along the path, they fall into the lake, taking 2d10 direct magical damage as they are submerged within the flames.

GM Tip! You may adjust the level of gore and emotional manipulation in the following encounters according to the preferences of your table. For example, if a character refuses a lustful offer, you may describe the faces of their loved ones deforming and melting within the lava

while screaming and asking why the character betrayed them.

Envy

If the chosen deadly sin for a character is Envy, they hear whispers saying, "*It cannot be helped. They have what you do not. Will it ever be the same? Take their place!*" A reflection of an old rival appears ahead on the path, walking effortlessly without chains. The figure moves with confidence.

If the character reaches toward the reflection to take its place, their bodies begin to overlap, but the reflection resists and tears through the character, dealing 1d10 direct magical damage. However, after taking the damage, the character finds it easy to walk and no longer requires a roll to move along the path.

If the character refuses, the reflection continues forward, dragging the chains that bind the character with it and increasing the Difficulty of the roll required to move along the path to 20.

Gluttony

If the chosen deadly sin for a character is Gluttony, they hear whispers saying, *"You are starving. Consume. Fill the void... Let the feast worry about the rest."* A feast appears along the narrow path, impossibly balanced above the lava below. The smell is overwhelming, and the food shifts to match the character's deepest cravings. The chains loosen slightly, as though allowing indulgence. The feast is visible only to the creatures who hear the whispers.

If the character stops to consume the feast, the food burns like molten gold within their throat, dealing 1d10 direct magical damage. However, the chains binding the character form a primal chair-like structure for them to sit upon, and the chains carry the character safely toward the door.

If the character refuses to indulge, the hunger becomes unbearable, and the chains tighten violently, increasing the Difficulty of the roll required to move along the path to 20.

Greed

If the chosen deadly sin for a character is Greed, they hear whispers saying, *"You left it all behind. Your wealth, your power... they are still yours."* To the character's right, a platform emerges bearing a massive pile of treasure. Gold spills across its surface alongside jewels, crowns, and relics glowing beneath the firelight.

If the character reaches for the treasure, the platform suddenly disappears, and the character is engulfed by the lava below, vanishing completely. After a brief moment of extreme heat and agony, the character emerges beside the black door.

If the character refuses the treasure, the thought of the wealth left behind becomes overwhelmingly unsettling, increasing the Difficulty of the roll required to move along the path to 20.

Lust

If the chosen deadly sin for a character is Lust, they hear whispers saying, *"You were never meant to walk alone. Embrace them. Feel the warmth of their touch again. Feel them."* Figures begin to form within the lava below, taking the shapes of past lovers, family members, and companions. The figures emerge from the flames, reaching upward toward the character. They extend their hands, offering to guide the character safely toward the door.

If the character accepts the invitation by holding their hands, the burning touch of the figures deals 1d10 direct magical damage. However, the figures swiftly drag the character toward the door with unnatural ease.

If the character refuses their help, the figures begin pulling at the character from below, attempting to drag them into the lava, increasing the Difficulty of the roll required to move along the path to 20.

Pride

If the chosen deadly sin for a character is Pride, they hear whispers saying, *"The path is beneath you. You know what that means: you are above this. Shut your eyes, walk as you always have, do not doubt*

yourself. What you see is an illusion, after all. Besides, who the hell are these people standing next to you? Who are they? What did they do to earn the right to walk beside you? Close your eyes. You do not need to see. You already know the way."

If the character closes their eyes and walks the path, they do not fall. However, each step causes small leaks of lava to break through the stone where their feet touch, burning into them and dealing 1d10 direct magical damage. Despite this, the character moves with unnatural certainty and reaches the door with ease.

If the character refuses and keeps their eyes open, the path remains narrow and unstable. The chains tighten sharply, pulling against them as though punishing their doubt, increasing the Difficulty of the roll required to move along the path to 20.

Sloth

If the chosen deadly sin for a character is Sloth, they hear whispers saying, *"You have done enough. Rest now, just for a moment. You deserve it."* The narrow path softens beneath their feet, widening into a stable and comforting surface with a bed resting upon it. The heat begins to fade, and the chains grow heavy, encouraging stillness.

If the character gives in and rests, the bed slowly drops into the lava and drifts toward the door. During this process, the character takes 1d10 direct magical damage from prolonged indirect contact with the lava.

If the character refuses to rest, exhaustion begins weighing heavily upon them, and the chains tighten sharply, increasing the Difficulty of the roll required to move along the path to 20.

Wrath

If the chosen deadly sin for a character is Wrath, they hear whispers saying, *"They wronged you, and they still breathe. Strike them down. Make them suffer."* Figures appear on the path ahead, taking the forms of enemies, rivals, or those who caused the character pain. They block the way, taunting and provoking the character.

If the character gives in to their fury and attacks, they find themselves charging toward the figures and striking them relentlessly. The figures explode into flame, dealing 1d10 direct magical damage, but the force of the assault carries the character safely toward the door regardless.

If the character refuses their wrath, the figures begin dragging the character toward the lava, increasing the Difficulty of the roll required to move along the path to 20.

Reaching the Door

At the end of the path, the towering black door stands before the characters. The door is engraved with twisted infernal figures, their forms writhing across the metal as though frozen mid-scream. At its center and along its frame are seven sigils, each carved deep into the surface and each representing one of the deadly sins.

As the last character approaches, one of the sigils begins to glow. The characters may understand that the glowing sigil represents Wrath (Difficulty 10). From within the glowing sigil, an **Avenging Spirit** emerges. The spirit represents the souls consumed while attempting to pass through the path. Consumed by overwhelming anger, it descends upon the characters in fury, believing that the "living" must somehow be responsible for their deaths.

AVENGING SPIRIT

Tier 1 Solo

A spectral warrior of ash and scorched flesh, formed from the souls of those who fell on the path. Its burning gaze is fixed on the living with relentless fury, with a sword and a shield of the wrathful knight, one in each hand.

Motives & Tactics: Maim and kill, bash enemies into lava.

Difficulty: 13 | **Threshold:** 8/14 | **HP:** 9 | **Stress:** 3
ATK: +3 | **Attack Name:** Melee | 1d12+2 mgc

Experience: Avenge +2

FEATURES

Bashing Strike - ***Action:*** Mark a Stress to make an attack against a target within Melee range. On a

success, deal 1d12+2 magical damage and the target is pushed to a Close Range. The Spirit uses this action to bash the characters into the lava. ***Protected by the Fallen - Reaction:*** When the Avenging Spirit is affected by a successful attack that marks its final HP, spectral hands emerge from the ground, covering the Spirit. The spirit takes no damage and doesn't mark the HP. The Avenging Spirit can use this reaction once per scene.

Read this section to your players.
With the Avenging Spirit slain, the sigil of Wrath, which once burned with cold fury, fades into darkness. The door falls silent for a brief moment. Then, you hear the mysterious voice: *"And so, the unfortunate souls put an end to the misery of another and embraced the next step toward their new life."* With a deep, echoing groan, the black door slowly opens, as though aware of your suffering. Beyond it, only darkness awaits, and the darkness is welcoming.

GM Tip! If the characters hesitate to move forward on their own, they hear the same voice once again. *"With a brief moment of hesitation regarding what came next, the unfortunate souls gathered their courage and moved steadily toward the black gate."* As the words settle into the darkness around them, the characters begin moving whether they resist or not. Forced forward by an unseen will, they walk toward the open door.

Episode 2: Chains of Guilt

After the first episode of torment, the characters find themselves in a completely different environment from the previous one. They are within a ballroom where they may encounter various guests, as well as their identical twins. These twins are better dressed, embody their affiliated sins more fully, and appear superior in every visible way, at least on the surface. The characters must eliminate their twins in order to break the glowing Envy sigil upon the ballroom's giant door and proceed further. The chains binding the characters are no longer visible, though they still exist. Once the encounter ends, the characters realize that the chain marked with Envy runes has vanished.

GM Tip! This episode works best when the characters feel psychologically cornered rather than physically threatened. Push the idea that the twins are not merely enemies, but reflections of everything the characters secretly desire, regret, or hate about themselves. The ballroom should feel oppressive despite its beauty. The guests may casually compare the characters to their twins in cruel ways, praising the twins while diminishing the characters without hesitation. Let the environment itself reinforce feelings of inferiority and paranoia. You may emotionally manipulate the characters through temptation, humiliation, or personal guilt if your table is comfortable with it. The twins should understand the characters better than anyone else. They may speak with the voices of loved ones, reveal insecurities, mock failures, or force the characters to confront truths they desperately avoid. The goal of the episode is not survival, but psychological erosion. If your table is comfortable with darker themes, you may make the twins disturbingly persuasive rather than openly hostile. They may attempt to convince the characters that they truly are the lesser versions, that the twins deserve to live more than they do, or that replacing the characters would improve the lives of everyone around them. You may even allow the characters to willingly surrender themselves. If a character chooses death and allows their twin to take their place, the Envy sigil still fades, and the twin replaces the character within the party. However, after the replacement occurs, the player eventually realizes the horrifying truth: the twin was never truly superior. The twin possesses exactly the same statistics, capabilities, and limitations as the original character. The character had always lived alongside the twin within themselves, but was unwilling to accept its existence. The only true difference was perception.

Read this section to your players.

The ballroom stretches far beyond what its walls should allow. It is vast and filled with tables bearing uncanny feasts, humanoid flesh, goblets filled with tears and blood, and countless other horrors. Candlelight spills from massive chandeliers whose flames burn without flickering. The light is warm. However, it brings no comfort.

The floor is polished marble veined like cracked bones. The walls are decorated with thick crimson veils. Infernal guests chat amongst themselves, plot one another's demise, crack unholy jokes, and carry on as though nothing is unusual. An orchestra of imps plays an infernal tune throughout the hall.

How To Get Out

At the far end of the ballroom stands a massive black door, much like the previous one. The door is carved into the wall with remarkable masonry. Six runes are etched across its surface in a circular pattern, and one of them glows with a faint yellow light. The characters may deduce that this is the rune of Envy (Difficulty 13).

The rune's glow fades, the door opens, and the scene ends only when the characters eliminate their twins or choose submission, as described in the previous GM Tip! The Important Guests can prove very helpful in eliminating the twins.

Important Guests

Read this section to your players.

The ballroom appears crowded. Figures dressed in elegant, tailored suits move across the floor. Some wear masks to conceal their faces, while others display them without fear.

The characters may speak with the figures as long as the GM sees fit. None of the guests acknowledge who the characters truly are or why they have arrived. If the characters ask what this place is or what the ball is celebrating, the guests explain that the gathering was organized in honor of four distinguished guests and point toward the twins.

The twins do not appear directly identical, but rather as idealized versions of what the characters could have become. Their doubles stand among the guests with ease. Their clothes are finer and perfectly fitted. They look as though they belong here. Their expressions are calm, composed, and complete. No visible flaws can be found upon them. They are part of this place in a way the characters are not.

As the characters observe them, their doubles slowly turn to face them. Their eyes meet. The twins recognize the characters immediately and view them as inferior versions of themselves.

There are several possible ways to eliminate the twins, listed according to the deadly sins with which the characters are affiliated. A greedy character does not necessarily need to eliminate their twin through the method listed under "Greed." However, the title "Greed" describes the behavior and personality of the greedy character's twin, as well as one possible method of eliminating them.

Wrath

The wrathful twin provokes the characters relentlessly. They insult them, mock them, and wait for the characters to draw their blades so they can unleash their fury upon them. If the characters act hostile and the whole party enters combat, the other twins will be there to support the wrathful twin.

The wrathful way to eliminate the wrathful twin is to kill them in direct and brutal combat. If the characters attempt to delay the fight or disengage from it, the twin grows increasingly enraged and their insults become even more vicious.

Envy

The envious twin is particularly admired by the crowd. Guests praise them, gather around them, and openly revere them. If a character acts openly hostile toward the envious twin, the

other guests interfere and attempt to calm the situation.

The envious way to eliminate the twin is through assassination. The characters may discover a method to assassinate the twin (Difficulty 15). They may find poison, identify a movement pattern that leaves the envious twin isolated, and so on. If the characters choose not to engage the envious twin in open combat, they may instead attempt the assassination through a Difficulty 17 roll. These methods may include secretly poisoning the twin, burning them inside a room, crushing them beneath a heavy chandelier, and similar acts.

Pride

The prideful twin is perfect in every visible way. They are confident, admired, and flawless in their movements.

The prideful way to eliminate the prideful twin is through public humiliation. This may be achieved through a duel, a performance contest, or even a public debate. Therefore, eliminating the prideful twin outside of combat is also possible (Difficulty 17).

Greed

The greedy twin is a wealthy figure who possesses everything the greedy character could ever hope to have in life.

The greedy way to eliminate the greedy twin is to take everything from them (Difficulty 17). This may be achieved through a gambling session, swift hands capable of stealing the twin's most valuable possession, or simply by taking their life. It is recommended that the gambling session be played out in-game rather than resolved through a single roll.

Lust

The lustful twin is exactly what the character desires. However, the twin does not feel the same toward the character.

The lustful way to eliminate the lustful twin is to seduce them, reject them, or assert dominance over them, ultimately declaring that the lustful twin is not something worthy of desire (Difficulty 17). The exact method may be emotional, physical, or something deeper. The GM should determine the nature of the encounter according to the table's dynamics and player boundaries.

Gluttony

The gluttonous twin indulges endlessly in food, drink, sensation, and music. Nothing prevents them from consuming without limit.

The gluttonous way to eliminate the gluttonous twin is to match or exceed their level of consumption (Difficulty 13, 14, and 15). Eliminating the gluttonous twin outside of combat requires three consecutive successful rolls as the characters overindulge themselves through excessive consumption. This demands repeated rolls as the characters surpass greater and greater thresholds of indulgence.

Sloth

The slothful twin does nothing but sit, rest, and ignore everything around them. They neither act nor react, as though time itself has stopped for them. However, they do respond if directly threatened by the characters.

The slothful way to eliminate the slothful twin requires cooperation with the other characters. The slothful character must remain still and uncaring while the guests tempt them endlessly, while the other characters must find a way to make the slothful twin care about something (Difficulty 17). They may burn them, cause mayhem at their table, and so on.

The Poet's Verse

When the characters somehow eliminate their twins, they hear the following words in their minds.

"They beheld themselves, and the self was answered,
The mirror spoke the truth, and was met with hunger.

What stood across them fell, yet nothing was mended,
The sin endured, only carried further.
So was the first hand raised, and the stain took chain,
As he was marked, so too remain,
Children of Cain."

After the characters hear the words, the glowing Envy rune fades out, and the giant door opens, calling the characters to move further.

Episode 3: Unending Hunger

Read this section to your players.
You find yourselves somewhere entirely different. You stand inside a massive rectangular feast hall that stretches so far into the distance that you cannot properly perceive its end. The ceiling rises high above you, vanishing into darkness. Endless rows of long banquet tables running through the middle divide the hall into two narrow pathways along the sides. At first, the tables are completely empty. Not a single plate, goblet, or crumb can be seen. As you move forward, you notice another black door standing at the far end of the hall. Unlike the previous gates, this one bears only five remaining sigils, with one of them glowing with a sickly, faint orange light. Only then do you realize the chains constricting you once again, one fewer than before. And only then do you notice the empty tables slowly beginning to fill.

The characters may deduce that the glowing rune represents Gluttony (Difficulty 10), and this time the chains do not force them to move anywhere. They are merely there to witness.

The characters quickly realize something deeply unsettling. No matter how long they walk toward the door, it never grows any closer. The hall itself stretches alongside them. Time becomes uncertain within this place; minutes feel like hours, and hours feel like days.

At first, the food appears ordinary. Roasted meats, fresh bread, ripe fruit, sweet wine, and warm soups are laid before the characters for consumption. The smell alone becomes overwhelming after what feels like days of endless walking. The food truly appears fresh, hot, and perfectly suited to the deepest cravings of whoever gazes upon it. If the characters consume the food, they immediately realize that no matter how much they eat, the hunger does not fade. Their stomachs remain painfully empty. The taste of the food is blank as well.

If the characters taste the food, they hear a whisper from the Poet: *"Maybe... just maybe, you should have eaten something else to satiate your hunger."*

After what feels like days of walking, as the hall stretches onward, the nature of the feast slowly begins to change. At first, the meals merely grow unpleasant to look upon. Fresh bread hardens into stone-like crusts, fruits blacken and collapse inward with rot, and meat begins to smell sour and spoiled. Wine thickens with clots and ash. Flies gather in vast swarms around the tables, yet the hunger remains unbearable enough to make even the rotten food tempting.

If the characters decide to taste the food regardless, do not hesitate to inform them that the taste is impeccable, better than anything they have ever consumed before.

After what feels like months of walking, as the hall stretches onward, the feasts become increasingly unnatural. The chunks of meat grow larger, and the characters may deduce that the flesh is humanoid (Difficulty 15). Goblets filled with blood, tears, bile, and boiling body fat are laid out for consumption. Fist-sized fruits pulse faintly as though they are beating hearts; when bitten, they bleed. Although the feast appears grotesque, the smell remains incredibly tempting.

The taste of the food here is even better than before, and consuming it becomes addictive. If

the characters taste any of the feast, they must resist the urge to continue consuming it (Difficulty 18). Satisfying their hunger through eating is impossible.

After what feels like years of walking, as the hall stretches onward, the characters discover five iron cages suspended from chains while the feast upon the tables remains unchanged. Inside the cages are a **Tiny Red Ooze**, a **Petty Noble** dressed in clothing that was once luxurious while a **Swarm of Rats** writhes beneath their skin, a silent **Courtier** with a sewn mouth, a **Giant Mosquito** bloated with black blood, and a starving **Minor Demon.**

If freed (Difficulty 14), the prisoners immediately descend upon the tables in a frenzy, consuming everything within reach with animalistic violence. Food, plates, silverware, wood, wax, and bone are devoured alike, yet nothing satisfies them.

The Poet whispers to the characters, *"What if?"* The whisper is meant to encourage the characters toward an even darker temptation: consuming the prisoners themselves.

Doing so should carry severe consequences. These prisoners are corrupted manifestations of endless hunger, and consuming their flesh spreads that corruption into the characters. Characters who eat them may temporarily reduce their hunger, but they immediately develop horrifying side effects depending on the creature consumed. The GM is encouraged to tailor these consequences to the tone of the table.

Possible consequences include violent vomiting, swarms of insects moving beneath the skin, insatiable cravings for raw flesh, teeth loosening or sharpening unnaturally, temporary madness, uncontrollable aggression toward allies, or the sensation that something alive is moving within their stomachs. Any relief gained from feeding should last only a few moments before the hunger returns even stronger than before.

Eventually, the Poet whispers once more. *"What if only you can feed yourself?"* The whisper is meant to encourage the characters toward consuming themselves. As the hunger becomes unbearable, the thought no longer feels impossible within the hall. The characters may begin staring at their own flesh, listening to their own heartbeat, or imagining how much suffering might be eased with only a single bite.

The Nature of the Hall

The feast hall is not meant to be escaped through violence, cleverness, or indulgence. The more the characters consume, the stronger the hunger becomes. The more they attempt to satisfy themselves, the more unbearable the emptiness grows.

You, as the GM, should set the tone so that the characters begin arguing with one another over food, resources, or desperation. The Poet's whispers may encourage paranoia, selfishness, or cannibalistic thoughts. Particularly desperate characters may even consider consuming parts of themselves or one another.

However, the true way to escape the hall is complete refusal. If the characters resist every temptation and choose to consume nothing despite the endless hunger, their bodies eventually begin to fail. One by one, they collapse from exhaustion and starvation.

To represent the effects of the growing hunger, apply a cumulative -1 penalty to all rolls each time the feast changes and the characters refuse to eat from it. The penalty represents weakness, exhaustion, delirium, and the physical toll of starvation within the hall. The cumulative penalty is reduced by 1 each time the characters complete a long rest.

When the characters finally decide not to eat any further, they eventually pass out. When they awaken once again, they find themselves lying directly before the black door, and they hear the Poet's Verse.

The Poet's Verse

When the characters finally collapse before the endless hunger and refuse every temptation of

the hall, they hear the following words within their minds.

"The starving mouths denied the feast,
Alas, the hollow grew beneath.

The flesh cried out, the marrow wept,
They endured where hunger slept.

Fed on nothing, still remained,
For emptiness cannot be chained..."

After the characters hear the words, the glowing Gluttony rune slowly fades into darkness, and the massive black door groans open before them, allowing the characters to move further into the Poet's mindscape.

Episode 4: Do Not Open Your Eyes

Read this section to your players.
The torments so far were nothing more than fever dreams. You feel as though you have awakened from a long, long nightmare. Finally... You are within your homestead, carrying out your life as usual. You awaken in your bed. You hear the voice you hear every morning. You feel safe and comfortable. Everything is finally alright.

The characters believe that the previous torments were nothing more than fever dreams and that they have finally awakened. In truth, the story written and directed by the Poet is still ongoing.

This chapter consists of four Acts of Reawakening. In each act, a character encounters a morally troubling situation that slowly reveals the horrifying truth that they are still trapped within the nightmare. Upon realizing this, the act ends, and the characters awaken once more.

These acts contain morally gray and emotionally difficult themes. The GM is strongly advised to read the encounters beforehand. Feel free to alter these encounters, soften them, or write entirely new ones in a similar vein if you believe the original material may be too harsh for your table.

Be advised that what matters most is the illusion of peace. The characters should continue living their lives, either together or separately. They should carry out daily routines, make a living, grow older, build homes, form relationships, marry if they wish, raise children, and experience the comfort of ordinary existence. The longer this false peace lasts, the more effective the episode becomes.

The GM is encouraged to extend this episode as much as desired. You may even run lighthearted one-shots or simple Tier 1 adventures within this false reality to reinforce the sense of safety and normalcy. Allow the players to genuinely believe they survived the torment and returned home before introducing the following Acts of Reawakening or writing your own.

GM Tip! To preserve the element of surprise, we recommend taking your players aside one by one and running the following Acts privately, without the other players seeing or hearing what is happening. Once a player's act concludes, they may return and join the others who have already completed their acts or are waiting for their turn.

Act 1: Please, Stay With Me

As the GM, select one of the characters for this act. Long after the horrors they once endured, the character has finally found peace. They have built a quiet life beside someone they deeply love, perhaps raising a family and growing older together. After setting the scene, read this section to your player.

After setting the scene, read this section to your player.
One night, amidst the laughter and comfort of familiar company, you hear frantic knocking at the door. The room falls silent, disrupted only by the sound of a quill scratching across parchment; then the knocking continues.

Your friend opens the door to find a terrified messenger standing outside, breathless and pale.

"They need you. Now."

For a brief moment, the world feels distant. The warmth of the fire suddenly feels heavier. The chair beneath you feels softer than before. Your body aches with an exhaustion you do not remember earning. The smell of food, drink, and burning wood wraps around you like a blanket. Your friend places a hand upon your shoulder.

"You are drunk," they whisper gently. *"Rest for a moment first. You can still go after."*

The character must first force themselves to rise from the chair (Difficulty 13), then stumble toward the door (Difficulty 15), run through the streets toward their own house (Difficulty 20), and finally climb the stairs to reach their spouse and unborn child (Difficulty: Impossible), which they cannot manage.

Read this section to your player.

You force yourself through the door before it is too late, but no matter what you do, you arrive moments too late.

The room smells of blood and sweat. Your spouse lies motionless upon the bed. As you stare at the scene before you, the walls stretch unnaturally tall, the candlelight darkens into crimson, and somewhere nearby you hear the scratching of a quill against parchment, as though a sentence has just been written and abruptly stopped.

Act 2: Please, 5 More Minutes

As the GM, select one of the characters for this act. Long after the horrors they once endured, the character has finally found peace. They have built a quiet life beside someone they deeply love, perhaps raising a family and growing older together. Their days have become ordinary in the best possible way: warm meals, familiar faces, small routines, and the comfort of knowing that the suffering is finally over. For the first time in a very long while, the character truly believes they are safe.

After setting the scene, read this section to your player.

You are sleeping beside someone you deeply love. Rain falls softly outside. The room is peaceful.

Then you hear something downstairs. Heavy footsteps. The sound of heavy breathing accompanies the slow creak of a door opening. Your loved one, half-asleep, whispers:

"Please check downstairs."

You immediately understand that something terrible has entered the home. However, the bed has never felt this soft. The warmth beneath the blankets feels safer than everything else. Your body refuses movement as survival instinct and exhaustion clash within you. Your loved one, sounding far more worried this time, whispers once again:

"Can you check what's happening?"

Then you hear another voice within your mind, a familiar tone you cannot fully recall. It feels as though you have not heard it in a lifetime.

"Please... five more minutes..."

The second voice belongs to the Poet.

The character must first force themselves to awaken (Difficulty 15), then get out of bed (Difficulty 17), walk toward the downstairs door (Difficulty 20), and finally descend the stairs (Difficulty: Impossible), which they cannot manage.

The first time the character fails any of these rolls, the loved one beside them wakes up and goes downstairs instead, whispering in an annoyed voice. *"Five more minutes, my ass."*

Read this section to your player.

While you struggle to wake up and make your way downstairs, the noises below grow worse.

Furniture breaks. Your beloved screams. You hear the sound of a massive beast's maw chewing through flesh. Then the scream of your loved one fades into the darkness as they are dragged through the broken doorway of your home.

You hear the voice of the Poet once again. *"You are finally awake for the first time in your life."* Your vision begins to blur...

Act 3: The Last Goodbye

As the GM, choose one of the characters for this act. Long after the previous horrors, the character lives a simple and peaceful life beside their aging parents. Their days are repetitive but comforting. Early mornings, warm meals, familiar conversations, and the quiet sounds of rural life have replaced fear and suffering.

Morning light pours softly through the windows of the family home. Rain from the previous night still clings to the glass. The smell of fresh bread fills the room. The character's mother prepares breakfast while their father slowly gets ready for another day of work in the fields. He is growing older now. His movements are slower than they once were, though he still insists on working despite everyone telling him to rest more often. The morning feels painfully ordinary.

The mother asks the character to pass the butter (Difficulty 13). However, the character feels extremely tired this morning, and even partaking in such a small task feels demanding. The father smiles faintly as he asks the character to steep the tea for him (Difficulty 15). Upon a failure, breakfast continues regardless, though the father appears slightly disappointed as he carries out the task himself. The character's little sister asks them to bring more wood for the stove (Difficulty 17), since the fire is beginning to fade. Upon a failure, she goes outside to gather the wood herself, struggling greatly with the task.

After setting the scene, read this section to your player.

The morning drags onward quietly. After a long and pleasant breakfast, your father eventually rises from the table and begins putting on the old coat he wears while working. Before stepping outside, he pauses and looks back at you and his beloved family.

For a moment, he looks much, much older than you remember. He smiles.

"I'll be back before sunset. Love you all."

Your mother and little sister answer with matching love and sincerity. Then your father's eyebrow rises expectantly as he looks toward you. From the wrinkles upon his forehead, you sense that his family is what keeps this old man alive.

Even if the character wishes to answer back (Difficulty: Impossible), they cannot manage to do so. Their body remains still and their mouth shut, as though an invisible force prevents them from speaking, as though they are too exhausted to utter even a single word.

The character's father waits only a second before nodding quietly to himself and stepping outside into the cold morning air.

A few hours later, a neighbor rushes toward the family home carrying terrible news. The father has died in the fields. As the crushing realization settles upon the character that they never said the final goodbye back, they hear a familiar voice somewhere nearby. The Poet whispers softly. *"You could have just said it."*

Act 4: The Final Strap

As the GM, choose one of the characters for this act. In this false life, the character serves as the loyal squire of the greatest hero they have ever known. The knight is both a great commander and a mentor. More than that, she is a living legend, beloved by the people and respected throughout the land. The character has spent years beside her, learning discipline and purpose.

The settlement where they live is relatively peaceful and prosperous, protected beneath the knight's banner. At least, it was so until the horns sounded and scouts arrived at the gates

carrying horrifying news. A horde of demons marches toward the settlement. Despite the surrounding fear, the knight remains calm. She commands the character to prepare her for battle, after which the character may be declared a knight as well, should they prove worthy.

The armory smells of steel and gunpowder. Outside, the character hears frightened voices and the distant sound of war drums. Meanwhile, the knight prepares for battle in silence. She hands the character her longsword and asks them to sharpen it (Difficulty 13). The character's body already feels heavy with exhaustion. The warmth of the forge and the repetitive scraping of steel make their eyes feel heavy.

The knight trusts the character with her life, and the character has performed these simple tasks a thousand times before. Therefore, she feels no need to double-check the results and accepts whatever work is done.

She asks the character to oil the blade (Difficulty 15), since she does not wish for it to rust in demon blood. Then, the knight asks the character to bring her horse from the stable and calm it, since the animal senses the coming battle and has become uneasy (Difficulty 17).

Later, the knight gestures toward a table filled with healing draughts and battlefield potions and asks the character to prepare the mixtures in the correct amounts (Difficulty 20). At last, she asks the character to help her into her armor. She hands the character the final piece, the belt protecting her abdomen, and asks them to fasten it properly (Difficulty: Impossible).

After setting the scene, read this section to your player.

You manage to help the knight prepare for battle. However, deep down, you know the belt protecting the knight's abdomen does not feel properly tightened. Still, it appears secure enough, and you are too exhausted to adjust it further. Why bother tightening it again?

Moments later, the battlefield erupts into chaos. War horns echo across the settlement walls while fire rains from the sky beyond the gates. The screams of soldiers and demons blend together beneath the sound of steel crashing through flesh.

You continue fighting. Demonspawns fall before you while the knight terrorizes the battlefield. Demons collapse one after another beneath her blade. Hope itself survives through the sheer force of will she embodies.

But... It all happens because of a brief moment of negligence. A demon lunges forward through the chaos and lands a weak slash across the knight's torso. It is not even a powerful strike, yet it is enough to tear the belt apart.

The armor protecting the knight's abdomen separates and falls open. For a single brief moment, exposed flesh remains vulnerable beneath the broken armor. A massive claw punches directly into the opening. Your knight freezes, and hope dies alongside her as she collapses into the mud beneath the rain of ash and blood.

The demons surge through the shattered lines of defense like starving beasts unleashed upon a feast. You watch a man dragged across the street while clawed hands peel strips of flesh from his back as though skin were wet cloth. A woman trying to shield her child is split apart from shoulder to stomach by a horned creature that continues walking while her body falls into two separate pieces. Villagers fleeing through the streets are trampled beneath clawed feet until their bones burst through flesh like broken branches. One demon lifts a screaming guard by the jaw and slowly tears his head free, the spine stretching before finally snapping apart. You watch your beloved settlement being pillaged and defiled. Then you hear a voice that feels familiar, though you cannot remember from where. *"One more pull, and that was enough."*

At last, the turn to be maimed comes for you. The rest is silence.

Waking Up To Reality

After the final Act of Reawakening comes to an end, the characters abruptly awaken to reality once more. The characters find themselves lying upon filthy straw beds within a dark chamber. At the far end of the chamber stands another massive black door. Five sigils remain engraved

upon its surface. The rune of Sloth glows with a dim yellow light that slowly fades as the characters awaken.

As the final traces of light disappear from the sigil, another chain vanishes from the characters' bodies. In that moment, they realize their muscles ache violently, their limbs tremble uncontrollably, and even the smallest movement feels agonizing. It feels as though they have been asleep for years.

The Poet's Verse

When the visions end and the characters realize that they cannot move, the great black door opens and four succubi enter the chamber. Their movements are graceful and strangely gentle compared to the horrors the characters previously endured. They neither threaten the characters nor speak harshly to them. Instead, they carefully lift the characters from their beds as though tending to helpless patients. Then, the characters hear the voice of the Poet.

"They sought the hearth and named it grace,
Whilst ruin crept beyond their gaze.

The idle hand, the silent tongue,
Left love unsaid and deeds undone.

Thus closed they fast their weary eyes,
Children of dusk, where slumber lies."

The succubi slowly escort the characters toward the next chamber, to their next torture.

Episode 5: We Are One

After the fourth episode of torment, the characters find themselves within an opening as large as a small village, containing only a single longhall occupied by the characters and four succubi, all surrounded by a landscape drowned beneath shades of crimson and black. The ever-crimson sky above resembles a bleeding wound of flesh-like clouds and slow-moving storms. Tall and jagged cliffs surround the area, their surfaces covered in massive screaming faces pressed into the stone. Some appear as though they have melted into the rock itself, while others stare outward with hollow mouths frozen open in eternal agony. Rivers of fine wine slowly flow through the land, further illuminating the ground with crimson light. Twisted dead trees rise from the earth with bark resembling charred bodies, their branches bearing swollen eye-like fruits wrapped in thorns and flesh. Pale flowers shaped like teeth grow from the ground. At the center of this nightmare stands the longhall, warm and almost welcoming compared to the wasteland surrounding it.

The longhall has two doors, a main entrance and a black door that cannot be opened until the characters discover a way forward. Three sigils are carved upon this second door, and one of them glows faintly with purple light. The characters may deduce that it is the Sigil of Lust (Difficulty 10).

The characters are unable to move for several days, during which the succubi accompany and care for them. Even after the characters regain the ability to move, the succubi remain constantly nearby, continuing to engage with them.

Each succubus embodies a different aspect of lust. One dwells upon the excess of bodily pleasures, the second upon the excess of adoration, the third upon the excess of achievement, and the fourth upon the excess of repose. Their demeanors are shaped by their devotion to these forms of excess. They lust endlessly for delight, adoration, achievement, and repose.

For example, the succubus devoted to bodily pleasures constantly attempts to seduce the characters. The one devoted to adoration praises the characters excessively and expects affection and admiration in return. The succubus devoted to achievement admires the characters' journey and accomplishments thus far, speaking of their struggles with fascination and desire. The final succubus adores comfort and rest, encouraging the characters to remain within the safety and warmth of this place forever.

If the characters behave in ways that disrespect the succubi's ideals, the succubi become hostile. If pushed far enough, they may even kill the

characters, only to revive them afterward as though nothing had happened.

GM Tip! Allow the succubi to grow attached to the characters, and allow the characters to grow familiar with them in return. You may assign one succubus to each character to encourage deeper interaction and familiarity between them.

The way to pass this torment is either to kill the succubi or to please them by treating them in the same manner they treat the characters. However, whenever the characters attempt to comply, the succubi always desire more and more. If the characters grow too accustomed to behaving like the succubi and begin acting that way genuinely and from the heart, the sigil shatters on its own.

Killing the succubi is not an easy task. Whenever they believe themselves to be at a disadvantage during combat, they flee by taking flight. The characters cannot pursue them through the air, as the infernal chains binding them prevent flight. After 1d4 hours, the succubi return with fully restored statistics, having completely forgotten that the characters attacked them or acted hostile toward them.

If the characters comply with the succubi and attempt to move forward by indulging in their twisted games of lust, the succubi claim that the gate will open once they are truly pleased. They insist that satisfying their desires will shatter the sigil and grant passage beyond the black door. However, as is the nature of lust demons, satisfaction never truly lasts. No matter how much they are given, they always desire more of the concept they embody.

GM Tip! Keep the succubi playful, charming, and engaging at all times, allowing the characters to discover small beauties within their actions and behavior. They may ask the characters to perform seemingly harmless errands, such as picking flowers for them, climbing the mountains to gather wine from its source, walking into the dreaded forest to collect rare fruits, or accompanying them on a picnic beside the glowing river. As these small quests continue, you may gradually make the succubi both more demanding and more generous at the same time, as far as the players are comfortable with and the tone of the table allows. You can find the details of the succubi below, alongside a general succubus stat block to represent them.

SUCCUBUS

Tier 1 Solo
A beautiful fiend with wings, draped in silks, perfume, and blood-red roses. Their voice feels warm and gentle, yet every word hides hunger beneath it.
Motives & Tactics: Seduce, isolate, charm

Difficulty: 14 | **Threshold:** 7/15 | **HP:** 10 | **Stress:** 4
ATK: +3 | **Attack Name:** Close Range (Thornkiss) | 1d10+3 phy

Experience: Temptation +4

FEATURES
Thornkiss Lash - ***Action:*** Mark a Stress to lash a target within Close range. On a success, the target takes 1d10+3 physical damage and gets pulled into Melee range. The target becomes Vulnerable until the end of their next turn as infernal desire clouds their judgment.
Sweetest Whisper - ***Action:*** The succubus kisses a target within Melee range by making an attack. On a success, the target marks 1 Stress and cannot willingly move farther away from the succubus until the end of their next turn.
Charming Lips - ***Passive:*** By spending 1 Fear, the succubus can charm a creature who marked Stress because of the succubus. The succubus may command that a charmed creature must make an attack against a target designated by the succubus. After the attack, the creature is no longer charmed.

Seraphine Velour, Succubus of Bodily Delights

Every word she speaks sounds warm and intimate, even when discussing horrific things. She constantly invades personal space without realizing how unsettling it can be, and she treats physical sensation as the purest truth in existence.

Seraphine embodies lust through touch, taste, pleasure, and sensation. She adores silk, warm skin, soft fabrics, perfumes, music, hot meals, and the feeling of intertwined fingers. She becomes deeply offended if someone rejects comfort or refuses the indulgence she offers. To Seraphine, denying pleasure is the same as denying life itself.

She often lounges lazily beside the glowing river, dipping her fingers into the molten marrow-like liquid and letting it drip down her arms while speaking softly to the characters. She enjoys brushing dirt from their clothes, feeding them by hand, braiding hair, and tracing scars while asking how they were earned.

Her primary desire is the collection of Pale Teeth Flowers, the white blossoms growing beneath the twisted trees. She believes they bloom more beautifully when picked by someone thinking of another person. She asks the characters to walk into the forest and gather the freshest flowers for her so she may weave them into crowns and necklaces. If the flowers are brought carelessly or without affection, she becomes visibly saddened and distant.

GM Tip! Here are a few signature phrases from Seraphine.

- *"Come closer... Warmth was never meant to be lonely."*
- *"Pleasure is the only honest thing left in this world."*
- *"Why deny yourself what your heart already aches for?"*

Elyra Vaunt, Succubus of Adoration

They speak as though every conversation is deeply emotional and personal, become attached to people frighteningly quickly, repeat compliments constantly, and expect reassurance in return.

Elyra lusts for affection, validation, admiration, and emotional dependency. They adore the characters almost immediately and treat even the smallest gestures as meaningful acts of devotion. They remember every compliment ever given to them and grow quietly hostile if ignored for too long.

They constantly ask questions about the characters' feelings toward them: whether they were missed while away, whether the characters think they are beautiful, whether their company is preferred over the others, and so on. Their smile falters whenever affection is not returned with enough enthusiasm.

Elyra's greatest obsession lies upon the cliffside overlooking the valley. High above the longhall hangs an ancient mirror embedded into the rocky mountain, surrounded by screaming stone faces. Elyra believes the mirror reflects *"how deeply one is loved when looked at."* They beg the characters to accompany them there and speak praises of their reflection aloud while they listen. The more sincere the praise sounds, the more euphoric they become.

GM Tip! Here are a few signature phrases from Elyra.

- *"Tell me honestly! Did you miss me while I was gone?."*
- *"You do adore me, don't you?"*
- *"Please keep looking at me like that a little longer."*

Vaelor Duskbane, Succubus of Achievement

She speaks with intense fascination about struggle and ambition. She reacts to stories of pain and sacrifice with admiration rather than pity and treats every conversation like the prelude to a legend.

Vaelor lusts for greatness, accomplishment, victory, and legacy. She is obsessed with the characters' past triumphs and constantly asks about battles fought, enemies slain, and hardships endured. Failure disgusts her, but only when it comes from surrender rather than defeat.

Unlike the others, Vaelor rarely touches the characters. Instead, she circles them like a battle tactician studying a battlefield. She speaks often of destiny and seems genuinely excited

whenever someone overcomes fear, pain, or exhaustion.

Her obsession lies atop the crimson mountains surrounding the valley. There, hidden within ruined stone arches, rests a spring of fine wine flowing directly from the earth itself. Vaelor claims the drink sharpens resolve and feeds ambition. She asks the characters to climb the mountain with her and retrieve the wine from its source. The journey is dangerous and exhausting, which only makes her admire those who complete it even more.

GM Tip! Here are a few signature phrases from Vaelor.

- *"A life without struggle is a story unworthy of remembrance."*
- *"Ambition is such a beautiful hunger when it burns inside someone worthy."*
- *"I love the way you keep moving forward, even when the world tries to break you."*

Mirelle Somnus, Succubus of Repose

They speak softly and slowly, as though always half-asleep. They constantly encourage others to sit, lie down, eat, or stay a while longer, and they react to urgency with genuine confusion.

Mirelle lusts for rest, peace, comfort, and escape from burden. They see exhaustion as the greatest cruelty in existence and believe the outside world asks too much of everyone. To them, the longhall is a sanctuary rather than a prison.

They wrap the characters in blankets while they sleep, hum quietly beside the fire, and encourage them to forget whatever mission brought them here. Mirelle becomes distressed whenever someone speaks about leaving. At first, they are not angry, merely heartbroken.

Their favorite place is a quiet riverside grove hidden beyond the dead trees, where strange red fleshy fruits grow beside the streams. The fruits are unnaturally sweet and cause a heavy warmth to spread through the body after being eaten. Mirelle asks the characters to gather the fruits and spend an evening resting beside the river with them, listening to the distant storms and speaking of peaceful memories rather than painful ones.

GM Tip! Here are a few signature phrases from Mirelle.

- *"Stay a little longer... the world can wait until morning."*
- *"You look so peaceful when you finally stop struggling."*
- *"Come closer to the fire. Let the rest of the world exhaust itself without you."*

The Poet's Verse

When the characters kill the succubi or finally act in a way that pleases them, the glowing sigil upon the door fades into darkness and the characters hear a voice once more.

"They drank of touch and honeyed breath,
And kissed the velvet jaws of death.

They begged for praise, for warmth, for more,
Whilst want stood weeping at the door.

Thus bound by silk and sweetened chains,
They wore delight until it stains."

Another chain binding the characters disappears. Only two chains now constrict them, and the door slowly swings wide open. The characters may proceed to the next episode.

Episode 6: Dead Need No Treasure

After the fifth episode of torment, the characters find themselves upon the shores of a vast infernal sea beneath a crimson sky. The air tastes of salt, ash, and blood. Massive blood-red waves crash endlessly against cliffs of obsidian stone that completely surround the shores and block all passage beyond them.

The beach itself stretches 120 feet wide and 240 feet long. The smell of wet wood, sulfur, and rotting saltwater hangs heavily in the air. Scattered across the shore lie the remains of a shattered ship and half-buried skeletons. Rusted

anchors, snapped masts, torn sails, and cracked figureheads litter the black sands. Among the wreckage rests a massive pile of treasure.

Within the rock formations surrounding the beach lies the entrance to a massive cavern, inside which stands a colossal black door already left open. Two infernal sigils are engraved upon its surface. Neither sigil glows yet. The characters may deduce that the remaining sigils are the Sigil of Greed and the Sigil of Pride (Difficulty 10).

Unlike the previous torments, nothing blocks the characters from entering the cavern. The black door already stands open, waiting for them.

GM Tip! Allow the characters to realize very quickly that they may simply leave. Do not pressure them toward the treasure immediately. Let the silence itself tempt them. Also imply that the piles of gold and the other treasures appear real, useful, and well deserved after everything the characters have endured.

Among the wreckage, the characters may discover the following treasures:

- A chest of coins containing 1000 gold coins
- 1d6 Tier 1 Magic Weapons
- 1d4 Tier 1 Secondary Weapons
- 1d3 Tier 1 Armor
- 6 Common items
- 3 Uncommon items
- 1 Rare items
- 1d4 Common consumable items
- 1d3 Uncommon consumable items

You, as the GM, may determine the loot yourself or allow your players to roll for it. If the players roll first and you decide which items are present afterward, the treasure will feel far more real and obtainable to them. If a character takes more than one item, the previously taken item disappears. Each character may keep only one item from the pile.

If a character takes even a single item from the pile, read this section to your players, and remind them to act in real time.

The black door immediately slams shut with a thunderous impact that shakes the cavern and cliffs alike. One of the sigils begins glowing with a bright golden light, casting a flickering yellow shine across the shoreline. At the same moment, a deep infernal voice echoes from everywhere at once:

"Ten."

All remaining treasure slowly begins sinking into the sand and seawater.

"Nine."

What will you do now?

"Eight."

A massive wave crashes against the wrecked ship.

"Seven."

The sigil glows brighter. Reflections of gold shimmer across the wet shoreline.

"Six."

The bloodied seawater crawls farther onto the shore.

"Five."

The waves begin dragging entire piles of treasure back toward the infernal sea.

"Four."

This is your final chance to take what you need.

"Three."

The shoreline trembles softly.

"Two."

The sigil burns brighter.

"One."

All remaining treasure vanishes completely beneath the sand, and an infernal figure rises from the shore.

An infernal, ghostly demon wearing a pirate captain's outfit emerges from the ground and

shouts, *"You crave treasure, I crave blood!"* before attacking the characters who took items from the pile first. If no such characters remain, it attacks the others instead.

DREAD CAPTAIN

Tier 1 Solo
A ghostly demonic pirate captain wrapped in soaked velvet and infernal chains, dragging the smell of greed behind him.
Motives & Tactics: Hunt the greedy, overwhelm with numbers

Difficulty: 14 | **Threshold:** 8/15 | **HP:** 8 | **Stress:** 5
ATK: +5 | **Infernal Chains:** Melee | 1d12+4 phy

Experience: Captain +3, Raider +3

FEATURES
Marked by Greed - ***Passive:*** Whenever a creature within Close range picks up, carries, or uses treasure from the encounter, you gain a Fear.

Call of the Tide - ***Action:*** Thrice per scene, mark a Stress to summon a Drowned Raider Horde which appears at Far range.

Infernal Chains - ***Action:*** By spending a Fear, the Dread Captain makes an attack against a target within Close range. On a successful hit, the target is constrained. A constrained target must first lose the constrained condition on them to act in any other way (Difficulty 15). If a target is constrained, by marking a Stress, the dread captain can throw the creature within Long Range. The thrown creature takes 1d12 physical damage, if the creature hits another creature, they also take 1d6 physical damage.

Momentum - ***Reaction:*** When the Dread Captain makes a successful attack against a PC, you gain a Fear.

DROWNED RAIDERS

Tier 1 Horde
Ghostly demonic pirate corpses with rusted blades and broken jaws.
Motives & Tactics: Hunt the greedy, kill the wounded, raid

Difficulty: 12 | **Threshold:** 5/10 | **HP:** 5 | **Stress:** 3
ATK: +1 | **Rusty Sword:** Melee | 1d6+2 phy

Experience: Sailor +3

FEATURES
Horde (1d4+1) - ***Passive:*** When the Horde marks half or more of their HP, their attacks deal 1d4+1 additional physical damage instead.

Clawing Hands - ***Reaction:*** When a creature attempts to leave Melee range of the Horde, the target must mark 1 Stress or they cannot move until they spend a Hope or make an action to get away (Difficulty 13).

The Poet's Verse

When the Dread Captain dies, his body collapses into seawater. The crashing waves slowly calm, and the treasures vanish completely. The golden sigil upon the black door fades into darkness once more, and the massive door slowly opens again.

"The tide rolled black with gilded gleam,
And wake from a vicious dream.

They reached for gold with eager hand,
Whilst death lay smiling in the sand.

For greed is but a drowning chain,
That binds the heart through fear of gain.

Thus sang the deep beneath the foam,
'The dead need naught to carry home.'"

The characters may now proceed toward their final torment. If they managed to keep any items from the treasure piles and successfully killed the Dread Captain, allow them to retain those items moving forward.

Episode 7: Poet of Pride

After the sixth episode of torment, the characters find themselves chained upon small chairs made of bone. A single infernal chain wraps around their arms, chest, and legs tightly enough to bruise the flesh beneath them. The

characters quickly realize that this feels far more real than the previous encounters. They are no longer within the mindscape of the Poet.

The room itself resembles less a study room and more an unholy slaughterhouse. The walls are built from stone darkened and moist with blood. Thick candles made from rendered humanoid fat burn with dim yellow light, their melted wax crawling downward like rotting skin. The smell of blood, ink, and wet parchment hangs suffocatingly within the chamber.

At the center of the room stands a massive table formed entirely from humanoid bones. Skulls staring outward adorn the corners of the table, while its legs are formed from humanoid spines. Humanoid leather sheets are stretched across the surface, covered in endless lines of writing. Some pages still bleed slowly from fresh cuts sewn into the skin, while others twitch faintly whenever the quill touches them.

Around the chamber lie piles of discarded parchment, broken quills, severed fingers used as bookmarks, and bowls filled with black ink mixed with blood. Some of the parchment pages contain descriptions of things the characters recognize. Whatever the characters experienced had already been written upon the parchments. There was no free will.

It was all the will of the Poet, who stands behind the table, quill in hand, smiling menacingly at the characters.

— THE END OF THE DEMO ADVENTURE —